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NOBODY'S COLORS

A Greyhawk adventure for APL 3 (levels 1–4) · 4–6 characters · one 4-hour session
Perrenland, Richfest 576 CY

ART · Front cover (Art Brief §1)

PROOF — 2026-10-25 — scenes at "drafted" — not for release

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About this proof

Text, tables, statblocks, handouts and maps are complete as of the date on the cover. Dashed boxes mark where the house ink art goes (see the Art Brief). Every scene is still at status "drafted": this proof is for proofreading and Playtest #1, not for sale.

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ADVENTURE OVERVIEW

A family with no clan tries to buy a name with a horse, and hires strangers to carry the lie across a lake.

A Social / Travel / Heist one-shot for **average party level 1–4** (written for APL 3, with scaling for 1, 2 and 4). Broke would-be students, stranded on Lake Quag's western shore on their way to Greyhawk University, take a job walking a rich boy's "baggage" to the Duffkyyn Derby at Schwartzenbruin. The baggage is a racehorse. The boy forged his father's seal to enter her, the colors are rented from a dead house, and a patient moneylender has paid to see her lose. It is the **prequel** to the Ritterstadt line: whatever the party does, it ends at the northern packet with a patron's letter for the Registrar.

DATE

Wealsun 26 – Richfest 5, 576 CY — the house default year (see Timeline). The Duffkyyn runs on the middle day of Richfest, the midsummer festival week. It is the first Richfest of Voormann Franz's term, and the Landfrieden is proclaimed in his name. The one-shots are not contiguous: this one sits wherever a new character needs it, and the Derby runs every Richfest, so another year works without changes.

DESIGN FRAME

- **Thesis:** A name can't be bought, but it can be earned in front of witnesses. The Halbritters try to buy a place among the clans with a horse; the only thing that works is a daughter riding in her own name in a dead house's silks.
- **Expectation broken:** *Escort duty is a fight on the road.* The road fight is avoidable and should be. The real danger is paper: a forged seal, a rented color, an unsigned book, and a sponsor who has run.
- **Second break:** the people who *should* make the decisions can't. Corwin won't offer the ride, Adalinde won't ask for it, and Otwin can't be told. The players have to say it.
- **What this adventure refuses to do:** Nobody in it needs killing. The man who wins never touches a weapon. Every hostile is a working person with cousins.
- **Session spine:** the mare's **Condition** (Sound / Sore / Lame), set by Krul's **Sabotage Clock** on the boat and the **Spook die** in the stable rows. See The Mare, the Clock and the Cord.
- **Tone:** fourteenth-century Alpine town drama. Bells for the hour, clan colors on doorposts, small beer, and a law for everything.

PERRENLAND COLOR

Canon framing; see Canon Check.

- **Clan bands.** Every free house paints its clan colors on the doorpost at shoulder height: Meerijder red-over-black, Roodberg blue-over-white, Vuurzward a green so dark it reads as black. A clanless family may paint nothing and wear only undyed cloth, under the *Kleiderordnung* (the dress-law). The Halbritters wear grey. *(The clans are Living Greyhawk tier; the bands and dress-law are homebrew.)*
- **Titles.** *Herr* (a landed man), *Junker* (his son), *Jungfer* (his unmarried daughter), *Ratsherr* (a town councilor), *Schultheiss* (a town's chief officer), *Amtmann* (a steward). Hessel Amtmann's surname is not his job; he is sergeant of the house guard, and Aerden has been asking him for the keys for fifteen years.
- **Names and register.** Perrender speech is mixed in canon (a *Voormann* rules from Schwartzenbruin). The clans and the capital use the German civic forms above. The Kettenhaus and Traft use the Dutch forms of The Kettenhaus note (*Kettenmeester*, *kontor*, *van Traft*).
- **Feud is lawful.** A clan may declare *Fehde* against a house that wronged it, and the killing that follows is not murder. Killing a clansman without a declared feud is murder, and his clan pursues it for a generation.
- **The Derby peace.** Richfest week on the Flats is under a *Landfrieden*. At the gate, the stewards' men knot a **red cord** through every hilt and scabbard and seal it with wax. Cutting your own cord is a crime; cutting it and drawing is a hanging. Schwartzenbruin's company taverns took the cord from the Derby, which is why The Red Cord ties blades at its door (see SP-PBS-03-The-Red-Cord).
- **Money.** Perrenders count in **marks** (gp), **kleinmarks** (sp) and **pfennigs** (cp). A laborer

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earns 3 kleinmarks a day; a good horse is 75 marks.

- **Paper.** A debt is a *Schuldbrief*, sealed and witnessed. Forging a seal on one is a hand-cutting offense.
- **The Great Dying.** Thirty years ago a pox took one in three across the lake cantons. Whole houses died, and their colors are still on the Roodberg register because no one has had the heart to strike them. That is why a broker can rent a dead family's silks. *(Homebrew.)*
- **The patrol.** Schwartzenbruin meets every boat at its lake-gate and writes every answer down (see SP-PBS-03-The-Red-Cord).

WHAT THE LOCALS KNOW

- **In Aerden:** the grey house at the top of the hill breeds honest horses and has no colors. The daughter runs the yard. The son has a new saddle he lets no one see. Sergeant Amtmann has never bought his own ale at the Mountainview Rest in fifteen years. Sivert Vuurzward wants the farm and has said so in the market.
- **On the boat:** Rhennee barges shadow the shore in summer. Nobody sells bloodstock to bargefolk, and the barges never ask why.
- **On the Flats:** a farm mare nobody has heard of is entered under Ostvelt green, a house that died in the Great Dying. She opened at twenty to one. Somebody is laying money against her.

WHAT'S REALLY HAPPENING

Homebrew; see Canon Check.

The Halbritters. Three generations ago they came up from Nederboden with money and no clan, bought **Erlenhof**, bred honest horses, and earned a seat on Aerden's council — the most a clanless family can reach. In Schwartzenbruin the clans hold the Derby, the sale ring and the canton remount contracts. No Halbritter horse has ever run at Duffkyyn in Halbritter colors, because there are none.

Two years ago **Adalinde Halbritter** bred a grey mare out of the old Erlenhof line, the best horse the farm has had in forty years. Stable name **Maus**. Adalinde broke her, trained her, and is by far the better rider of the two siblings. She has wanted to enter the mare at Duffkyyn since the day she was foaled and has never said so.

Otwin Halbritter has settled the farm's future: a three-year contract for thirty remounts to the canton levy, to be signed before the remount commissioners at the Schwartzenbruin *Rathaus* at noon on Derby Day. It puts Maus in a levy string carrying a crossbowman.

Corwin Halbritter forged his father's seal on a Schuldbrief against the Erlen bridge tolls — 400 marks — and paid the entry. Having no colors, he rented a set from a Schwartzenbruin broker, Jorick Weisel: Ostvelt green. The mare is entered as *Ostvelt Grey*. Corwin means to ride her himself. He isn't good enough, and some part of him knows it.

Two Derby rules the adventure turns on. 1. **Colors.** Every entry runs under colors on the Roodberg register. Brokers rent dead houses' colors, and the stewards allow it, but a **living sponsor of record** must sign the book in the stewards' tent before post time. 2. **Rider.** The **sponsor of record names the rider.** Weisel named Corwin. To change the rider, someone must change the nomination, and Weisel means to be nowhere.

Sivert Vuurzward holds the note. He lends money, breeds horses, and wants Erlenhof: the land, the bloodline and the grey mare who comes with the farm if it falls. He knows the seal is forged. He needs only to say in the *Rathaus*, "Herr Halbritter, is this your seal?" Otwin cannot answer no without naming his son a forger before the whole canton. So a 400-mark paper controls a farm worth ten times that. Vuurzward needs the mare to lose, and has arranged it.

Whose money it is. Sivert bought the note on Kettenhaus credit, and the House of the Chain holds his paper on it: a Schuldbrief behind a Schuldbrief. This year the Kettenhaus's patron clan, the Hussen, has taken the Voormannship, and the house is calling in paper across the cantons while the window is open. Sivert is the face; the Kettenhaus is the chain. Nothing here needs the party to find out. See The Kettenhaus.

Hessel Amtmann posted the job because the house guard answers to Otwin. He is Corwin's accomplice, and the leak. He married a Vuurzward woman and owes 60 marks on a Schuldbrief her brother holds (Kettenhaus paper, though Hessel doesn't know it). Ten days ago, the day Corwin booked passage, Hessel sold the route, the boat and the date to have it struck out.

The morning of Day 1. Old Hartwin the tollkeeper walks up to the house to ask why a

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stranger in a dark Traft coat was out yesterday dragging a surveyor's chain across the Erlen bridge. (He was a Kettenhaus *Schätzer*, pricing the collateral.) Otwin finds out at dawn. Corwin's wagons left at first light. Otwin, who cannot ride for the gout, sends a boy on a pony to the Meerijder drovers camped at the bridge, with a writ.

VUURZWARD'S SCHEME

What happens if nobody interferes: 1. **Ten days before:** Hessel sells the route. Vuurzward hires Anse Krul, a farrier, for 40 marks, half paid at Osterschlauss, and opens an account laying money against Ostvelt Grey. 2. **On the lake:** Krul boards the *Kortheim Maid* and pricks the mare's hoof in the small hours of the second night. She walks fine and runs as if on coals. 3. **On the Flats:** if she is still sound, his bravos try again in the stable rows on Derby eve. 4. **At post time:** with no sponsor's signature, the line is struck, or Corwin rides a sore mare to the back of the field. 5. **Day 6:** the note falls due. Erlenhof goes to the sale ring, and the mare with it.

If the PCs never come: Corwin gets nine miles before Boedic's drovers stop him at the bridge. Otwin takes the mare home, Maus goes into the levy string, and Vuurzward buys the note's foreclosure the following year.

HOOK

1. **The notice (default).** At vespers in the Mountainview Rest, Sergeant Amtmann pins a notice to the post: escort duty, Aerden to Schwartzenbruin, passage paid, thirty marks on arrival. See Handout — The Notice.
2. **Grete's arrangement.** Grete Haslau has kept the party alive for three weeks on work-for-board. She tells them the job exists before Amtmann posts it: "*He'll come in tonight and pin something up. Read it before the drovers do.*"
3. **Personal stake.** A PC with a Perrender surname is claimed as clan kin by somebody in the first ten minutes, or a PC carries a debt that Vuurzward has quietly bought.
4. **Decline path.** If the party refuses the job, Adalinde finds them at the Rest that night with her own money and a straighter story, and comes with them.

PC OBJECTIVES (THE PLOT, AS GOALS RATHER THAN EVENTS)

1. **Find out what is in the third wagon.** *(Open it, read Adalinde, hear Boedic say "horse," or ask Tilo about the saddle.)*
2. **Get Corwin and the mare across the Erlen bridge.** *(Clan kinship, the jurisdiction argument, a bribe, a counter-writ, the cattle, night, or a fight.)*
3. **Get a racehorse aboard a passage booked for one man's baggage.** *(Pay Vosk, bribe the clerk, forge the roll, load at the wrong bell.)*
4. **Cross the lake with the saboteur aboard.** *(Stand watch; spot Krul; stop the clock.)*
5. **Get the entry signed.** *(Find Weisel, find a new sponsor, or win Roodberg.)*
6. **Keep the mare sound through Derby eve.** *(The stable rows.)*
7. **Settle who rides.** *(Say it, because nobody else will.)*
8. *(Optional)* **Find out who sold the route.** *(The ten days.)*

SUBPLOTS (KEYED TO PCS; ASSIGN AT THE TABLE)

- **Perrender surname:** claimed as Meerijder, Roodberg or Vuurzward kin. Boedic's drovers won't raise a hand to kin, and doors open at the Flats. Each use is a favor spent.
- **Knows horses** (animal-handling background or proficiency): the only one besides Adalinde who can tell the mare has been got at, and when.
- **Carries a debt:** Vuurzward has bought it by Scene 5. He mentions it once, kindly, and never again. It is why he makes his offer to *them*.
- **Trade, coin or bookkeeping:** reads Otwin's ledger in a minute (Scene 2) and the odds-book anomaly on sight (Scene 5).
- **Thief, forger or liar:** owns Scene 3.

ACT STRUCTURE

Likely path: Scenes 0 → 1 → 2 → 3 → 4 → 5 → 6 → 7 → 8.

ACT 1 — AERDEN AND THE ROAD (≈75 MIN)

- Scene 00 — Three Weeks in Aerden: The town, Grete's board, how broke everyone is, and the notice.
- Scene 01 — Erlenhof: The hiring, the terms, Adalinde at the fence, and the third wagon.

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- Scene 02 — The Erlen Bridge: Boedic, the writ, and the first real decision. If they're held, Otwin comes at dusk.

ACT 2 — LAKE QUAG (≈55 MIN)

- Scene 03 — Osterschlauss: Getting sixteen hands of grey aboard the *Kortheim Maid*.
- Scene 04 — Two Nights on the Quag: Passengers, the Rhennee offer, and Krul in the deck stall.

ACT 3 — THE DUFFKYYN FLATS (≈90 MIN)

- Scene 05 — The Stewards' Tent: The cord at the gate, the unsigned book, the odds-book, and Vuurzward's offer.
- Scene 06 — The Stable Rows: Derby eve, forty horses, corded blades, and the Spook die.
- Scene 07 — Post Time: Twenty minutes to the third bell. Who rides.
- Scene 08 — The Sale Ring: Otwin, the truth about Hessel, and the patron's letter.

CLIMAX AT A GLANCE

See Scene 07 — Post Time. Corwin can't win, Adalinde is in riding boots, and the book is unsigned. **Neither sibling will raise it.**

Route	What it takes	Seeded in
Adalinde rides	The nomination changed: Weisel at The Tanner's Rest made to sign, a new sponsor, or Roodberg persuaded the rule serves the race better bent than kept	S1 ("I ride"), S4, S5 (the rule), S7
A living sponsor for a dead house	A Roodberg or Meerijder breeder willing to sign, for a share of the mare's first foal	S5, a clan-kin PC
Buy the note down	Stake money at 4-to-1 to place, or the purse share	S1 (the share), S4, S5 (the odds-book)
Scratch her and take the offer	Corwin's yes, which he gives if the party tells him to	S5
Expose Vuurzward	Krul or a bravo as witness plus the odds-book account, laid before Roodberg. Vuurzward's own entries are barred; the note still stands.	S4, S5, S6
Run Corwin anyway	Nothing. He finishes sixth, honestly.	—

KEY NPCS

- Corwin Halbritter — *Junker*, 19. Forged the seal. Charming in a practiced way; from Scene 3 on he asks the party what to do, and means it.
- Adalinde Halbritter — *Jungfer*, 24. Runs Erlenhof, bred the mare, the better rider. Never lies to the party and will not ask for the one thing she wants.
- Otwin Halbritter — *Ratsherr* of Aerden, sixties, gout. Correct about the money, wrong about the boy, and can be argued with by anyone who asks to see the ledger.
- Hessel Amtmann — sergeant of the house guard; the accomplice and the leak.
- Sivert Vuurzward — moneylender and breeder. Courteous, patient, never threatens, never lies; he leaves things out.
- Anse Krul — farrier. Lames horses for money and calls it a trade.
- Boedic of the Meerijder — drover, holding a lawful writ he wishes he'd never been handed.
- Captain Marda Vosk — master of the *Kortheim Maid*. Prices everything, including silence.
- Steward Alric Roodberg — chief steward of the Duffkyyn. Not bribable with money; very bribable with correct papers.
- Jorick Weisel — color-broker (*Wappenmakler*). Already leaving.
- Grete Haslau — keeper of the Mountainview Rest. Refuses to be thanked.
- Tilo — Grete's yard boy, nine. Knows everything, tells it for a pfennig.
- Old Hartwin — tollkeeper at the Erlen bridge for forty years.
- Kaspar Roodberg — the farrier by the well in Aerden, who takes Derby bets.
- Ebbo Kühn — the Hafenmeister's clerk at Osterschlauss, keeper of the *Frachtrolle*.
- Zinka of the Kestrel — the Rhennee woman who makes the 600-mark offer.
- Benno — the stewards' boy at the Duffkyyn.
- Sergeant Ruwen Hask — the lake-gate patrol sergeant at Schwartzenbruin.
- **Offstage** (no notes, by rule): the Kettenhaus *Schätzer*, Gerlach Hanselmann, Voormann Franz.

KEY LOCATIONS

- Aerden — a slate-and-plaster market town in the Yatil foothills; the Mountainview Rest and Erlenhof are its features (Scenes 0–1).

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- The Erlen Bridge — the Halbritters' own toll bridge, and a Meerijder drover camp (Scene 2).
- Osterschlauss — Aerden's landing on the lake (Scene 3).
- The Duffkyyn Flats — the Derby ground outside Schwartzenbruin's walls: the gate, the stewards' tent, the stable rows, the course and the sale ring (Scenes 5–8).
- The Tanner's Rest — the tavern where Weisel drinks (Scene 7, or earlier if they hunt him).
- Schwartzenbruin — the capital and its lake-gate. Canon note in `20-World/Greyhawk-Canon`.
- *Transit, no note:* the Aerden road, the *Kortheim Maid* and the lake crossing, the northern packet.
- *Offstage, no note:* Traft (seat of the Kettenhaus), the Schwartzenbruin *Rathaus*.

ENCOUNTERS

Difficulty uses **4 PCs** and 2014 DMG thresholds and multipliers. **For 5–6 PCs, add one drover or bravo per extra PC.** Full statblocks are in Bestiary.

#	Name	Type	APL 1	APL 2	APL 3	APL 4	Notes
1	The Erlen Bridge (S2)	social, or combat	Boedic + 3 drovers — Deadly (1,500)	Boedic + 5 drovers — Deadly (1,900)	Boedic + 5 drovers + 2 mastiffs — Deadly (2,500)	same — Deadly (2,500)	**Avoidable, and built to be.** Any one approach ends it. Morale breaks at two drovers down.
2	Loading the Mare (S3)	skill	one DC	one DC	one DC	one DC	Failure is not refusal: the mare boards, and the roll records it
3	Krul on the Deck (S4)	clock combat	Krul alone — Medium (200)	Krul + 1 deckhand — Medium (450)	Krul + 2 deckhands — Medium (800)	same — Easy (800)	The Sabotage Clock: three uninterrupted rounds
4	The Stewards' Tent (S5)	social	—	—	—	—	Roodberg starts Indifferent
5	The Stable Rows (S6)	tactical combat	2 bravos — Hard (300)	3 bravos — Hard (600)	4 bravos + Krul — Hard (1,200)	same — Medium (1,200)	Blades corded; the Spook die; bravos help drag the fallen clear
6	Finding Weisel (S7)	social	—	—	—	—	Five minutes at a run

Adventuring-day check (APL 3, 4 PCs): a daily budget of 4,800. The likely path (bridge talked through, Krul, the rows) costs about 2,000 adjusted XP. A party that fights the bridge spends half the day on it, which is the point.

TREASURE & REWARDS

Getting to Ritterstadt. Admission costs only a signature on the Scholar's Oath. The northern packet from Schwartzenbruin is one night along the shore and **20 marks**. The Registrar asks a **first-term bond of 80 marks** in coin, or a term of labor on the levy (the Drill Yard, the Archive, the gate rota). **A hundred marks each arrives clear.** *(Recorded in RG-08 — Greyhawk University, Ritterstadt Field Station, both vaults, 2026-10-23.)*

Fixed. 30 marks each, 40 if negotiated, paid at the Schwartzenbruin quay. Passage Osterschlauss–Schwartzenbruin (40 marks' worth) already paid. One uncommon item from the Derby prize table, below.

The Derby prize table. By Duffkyyn custom, the company that brought a starter to the post draws one prize from the stewards' chest at the sale ring (Scene 08 — The Sale Ring). It goes to the party, not to each PC. Any branch where the mare reached the Flats under their escort qualifies, run or scratched; the Rhennee sale does not. Roll d6.

d6	Prize	Source
1	***Saddle of the cavalier***, tooled in Roodberg blue	DMG p. 199
2	***Lantern of revealing***, a stable lantern with the stewards' mark burned into the hood	DMG p. 179
3	***Goggles of night***, given "for the night watch"	DMG p. 172
4	***Rope of climbing***, a lead rope of silk and horsehair	DMG p. 197
5	***Bag of tricks (gray)***, a groom's feed bag	DMG p. 154
6	***Cloak of protection***, a drover's oiled cloak in undyed grey (the stewards' joke, if the party came with the Halbritters)	DMG p. 159

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Standard DMG items, so no `50-Items` notes, by rule.

Earned. - **Purse share.** Second place pays the owner 500 marks. "One part in five" (Scene 1) is 100 marks to split. - **Winnings.** 40 marks staked at 4-to-1 to place returns 160 profit plus the stake. - **Otwin's gratitude.** Where Adalinde rides and the farm stands, Otwin pays each PC's northern packet and half the bond, **60 marks a head**, out of his own strongbox, the first money in fifteen years he hasn't counted twice: "*The Rathaus clerk tells me the northern packet leaves Godsday. You'll be on it. Don't thank me; I'm buying your absence from my daughter's stable.*" - **The Rhennee sale.** 600 marks on the second night. Four hundred clears the note; Corwin gives the party the two hundred over. It costs the Halbritters their name.

The patron's letter (Extra Credit, outside the 600 limit). Adalinde brings it on almost every branch: a **letter of field expertise** from a Roodberg breeding patron, addressed to Registrar Hedwig Ammerlin. It does not open the door; the University takes anyone who signs the Oath. It counts once they are inside. **10 extra credit on its face, plus 10 for each commendation, three at most (40).** See Handout — The Patron's Letter.

Commendation, as the patron writes it	Earned by
"*Crossed the Erlen without spilling a drover's blood.*"	A bloodless bridge (S2)
"*Stood a watch nobody asked them to stand.*"	Krul stopped or captured (S4)
"*Brought her to the post sound.*"	Maus Sound at post time
"*Read a ledger like a clerk and a man like a priest.*"	The ten-days chain assembled (S4–S8)
"*Asked the question nobody in that family would.*"	The rider question solved, by any route (S7)
"*Told her father the truth when it cost them.*"	Told Otwin about Hessel (S8)

Not coin, not credit. A favor owed by Adalinde, Boedic or Roodberg, whoever they treated decently. Maus's first foal, if she is sound and unsold: three years out, worth more than everything above, and impossible to spend.

Experience. None. Advancement in the Greyhawk University frame is tuition, paid in credits. Characters leave at the level they arrived; the letter is what they carry forward.

Branch (4 PCs)	Coin each	How they reach Ritterstadt
Adalinde rides, they bet, purse share	200 + 25 = **225**; Otwin pays 60	Clear, with 185 marks in hand
Adalinde rides, purse share, no bet	40 + 25 = **65**; Otwin pays 60	Clear, with 25 in hand
Adalinde rides, no share, no bet	**40**; Otwin pays 60	Clear, with nothing left
Corwin rides, sixth	**40**	Packet; 20 left; on the levy
Vuurzward's offer taken	**40**	Packet; on the levy; letter in hand
Sold to the Rhennee	40 + 50 = **90**	Packet; 70 left; on the levy

DENOUEMENT

See Scene 08 — The Sale Ring. Otwin watched the last two furlongs from the public stand and told no one. Krul's "ten days," the odds-book account and Grete's ale line name Hessel Amtmann. Whether to tell Otwin is the last decision, and it is the party's. The northern packet leaves on Godsday.

ENDINGS AT A GLANCE

Ending	Condition	Result
A — In her own name	Adalinde rides a Sound mare	Second. The purse clears the note; Maus becomes a broodmare; Otwin strikes her from the levy string in his own hand
B — Honest and sixth	Corwin rides	Sound, sixth, no purse. The note falls due; Erlenhof goes to the Day 6 ring unless the party has arranged otherwise
C — Kept whole	Mare Sore, and they don't run her	Scratched by choice. Vuurzward's offer at Derby-evening prices
D — Run sore	Mare Sore, and they run her	Fourth at best, with a 1-in-6 breakdown rolled in the open. No purse
E — Paper beats horse	Vuurzward's offer taken, or past the third bell	Farm saved, mare gone. The letter is still delivered
F — Sold	The Rhennee sale	The line struck; the note cleared with the barge coin; the name lost on the Flats. A short Act 3 (Scenes 5 and 7 cut down, Scene 6 cut)

CONTINUITY

Threads this adventure **opens**: — Threads this adventure **advances**: — *(Sidebar Press threads)*

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Threads this adventure **closes**: — Dangling hooks left for future adventures (logged in Plot-Threads): - **Who wanted the mare?** Six hundred marks is far too much for a farm mare, and the Rhennee were told to watch that boat. - **The Kettenhaus paper.** Sivert's 400 and Hessel's 60 trace to the same house that holds Ritter Konrad von Eisfeld's Schuldbrief.

Ritterstadt continuity: the party arrives at The Landing on the northern packet with the patron's letter, clear or on the levy. Log the Extra Credit with the Registrar.

SOURCES

Canon element used	Sources to cite (page to verify)	How it is used
Schwartzenbruin, capital on the SW shore of Lake Quag, ~26,000; the lake-gate patrol	*WoG* (1983) pp. 29–31; *LGG* (2000) pp. 85, 153; SP-PBS-03-The-Red-Cord	The Derby city
Voormann Franz, took office 576 CY	*WoG* (1983) p. 30	The Landfrieden proclaimed in his name
Marks, kleinmarks, pfennigs	*LGG* (2000) p. 85	Prices
Longbowmen and bow-armed cavalry in Clatspurgen and Traft; crossbowmen in the lowlands	*LGG* (2000) p. 85	The remount contract (a crossbowman's horse)
Roodberg (Clatspurgen's clan), Vuurzward (mercenary tradition), Meerijder, Hussen	Living Greyhawk regional material; see Canton-of-Clatspurgen, Perrenland-Mercenary-Companies, The Kettenhaus	The three Derby clans; the Kettenhaus's patron
Lake Quag: boats keep the shore in sight; the shunned middle	Region Report 0003; SP-PBS-03-The-Red-Cord	Scene 4
Richfest, Wealsun, Godsday	*WoG* calendar; The-Common-Year-Calendar	The date

Deviations (homebrew): Aerden, Osterschlauss, Erlenhof, the Erlen bridge, the Duffkyyn Derby and Flats, the Tanner's Rest, House Halbritter, the clan bands and dress-law, the colors register, the Great Dying, the Landfrieden cord (the Red Cord's origin), the Rhennee barges on the Quag, every fare, and the first-term bond are invented. The Kettenhaus and Traft come from the Ritterstadt gazetteer.

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ACT 1 — AERDEN AND THE ROAD

SCENE 00 — THREE WEEKS IN AERDEN

ART · Scene banner: Aerden at dawn (Art Brief §3)

PURPOSE

The players leave this scene knowing what Aerden looks and sounds like, exactly how broke they are, and how they came to share a table — because they chose it. They are not friends. Yet. The notice is the last thing that happens.

WHY THEY ARE HERE

Every one of them is going to Ritterstadt, to enroll at Greyhawk University's field station across Lake Quag. The University takes anyone who signs its Oath. Getting there is the problem. The northern packet out of Schwartzenbruin, ninety miles down the shore, is one night to Ritterstadt's quay and 20 marks a head. At the far end the Registrar asks a first-term bond: 80 marks in coin, or a term of labor on the levy. **A hundred marks each to arrive clear**, and none of them has twenty. The free way is the shore road east to Traft and four days north on the caravan track: two weeks on foot, and nobody's idea of safe.

Hand this out first. Each player picks one or writes their own. No two the same.

How you came to be stuck in Aerden
The coach to the lake left a day early. Nobody told you.
You were hired to guard a wool wagon to Osterschlauss. The wool got there. Your pay didn't.
You came over the Yatil passes on foot to save the fare. The map said six days. It was fifteen.
A letter of credit drawn on a Krestible counting-house. No one in Aerden will honor it.
You were sick a week in a farmhouse outside town. The farmer's wife wouldn't take money, so you paid the innkeeper for the farmer's ale instead. That was most of what you had.
You won't say. You've been asked twice.

ARRIVAL

Aerden sits where the last of the Yatil foothills flatten into meadow. Everything is grey slate and cream plaster, and every doorpost in town carries a painted band at shoulder height: red over black, blue over white, a green so dark it looks black in shadow. Two doorposts are bare. One belongs to the inn. The other belongs to a big slate-roofed house at the top of the hill, with paddocks behind it.

To the table: "*You've eaten at Grete's long table for three weeks. Who at it do you still not trust, and why?*"

WHO IS HERE

- **Grete Haslau**, widow, keeper of the Mountainview Rest. *Wants:* her board squared and her house quiet after vespers. *Knows:* everyone's debts to the pfennig, and that Sergeant Amtmann has never bought his own ale in fifteen years, because every market day for a year he has paid a Vuurzward man at the well instead. *Reacts:* she refuses thanks, makes arrangements instead of giving credit, and has already decided the party are decent.
- **Tilo**, her yard boy, nine. *Wants:* pfennigs. *Knows:* everything. *Reacts:* tells it for a pfennig, in the order he thinks of it.
- **Old Hartwin**, tollkeeper at the Erlen bridge, at the small table by the door every third night. *Wants:* an audience. *Knows:* every wheel that crosses the bridge by its sound. *Reacts:* talks about the bridge until stopped.
- **Kaspar Roodberg**, the farrier by the well, a Roodberg cousin who shoes in the open and takes Derby bets between horses. *Wants:* your bet. *Knows:* the odds on every horse he's heard

of. *Reacts:* offers longer odds the less a horse is known.

- **Meerijder drovers**, up from the bridge camp most evenings: red-and-black on their sleeves, loud, honest and good at cards.

BEATS

THE TOWN, AS THEY LOOK

Read the box, then give these one at a time as the players look around, not as a list. - **The bands are clan colors, and painting them is law.** A house with no band has no clan. The people in the house on the hill wear grey; the dress-law says they may wear nothing else. - **The green** has arrow-chewed straw targets at the far end. On Godsday mornings the militia shoots there, longbows on foot and short bows from the saddle, and the whole town comes out with small beer to watch. - **Cheese** is the smell of the place: caves cut into the hill behind the market, milk carts before dawn. Under it, when the wind is west, the burnt-metal smell of the copper smelters at the foot of the pass. - **Half the men over forty** walk like soldiers and wear a foreign coin on a cord: Furyondy, Veluna, Ket. Perrenland's export is its sons. They notice armed strangers the way a carpenter notices a door hung wrong. - **The chapel bell** tells the day: first bell at dawn, the noon bell, the third bell when the market closes, vespers at dusk. Nobody owns a clock. - **Every conversation** gets to the Derby. Duffkyyn is a week off and ninety miles down the shore, and it is the only thing anyone wants to talk about.

GRETE'S BOARD

Chalked above the bar where everyone can read it. Fill it in from the players' choices and let them read it.

	Owes	Worked off
(PC)	2 marks 6	3 days, caves
(PC)	1 mark 9	yard watch, 4 nights
(PC)	3 marks —	—
(PC)	1 mark 2	wood, roof, one chimney

Let one of them notice who has worked off nothing, and let that be a conversation or not.

Grete, to anyone who tries to thank her: "Don't. I'll only put it on the board."

THREE WEEKS AT THE LONG TABLE

They know each other's names and what each one eats. Between them they have unloaded milk carts, mucked the Halbritter paddocks for a day-rate (3 kleinmarks, and a look from the woman who runs the yard that said *you've done this before*), stood a night watch on the cheese caves, and each lost four kleinmarks to a drover at cards. The University came up the first week, and since then it is the one thing they don't joke about. If a player wants to say what they mean to study, let them. Don't make them.

GOSSIP, IF THEY ASK

Ask	Answer (Tilo, for a pfennig)
The grey house?	"*Herr Otwin's got the gout and the Jungfer runs the horses and the Junker's got a new saddle he doesn't let anyone see.*"
The sergeant?	"*Sergeant Amtmann. His wife was a Vuurzward. She still paints her mother's door green. And he didn't pay the green man at the well this week.*"
The Derby odds?	Kaspar, the farrier by the well: "*Roodberg bay, three to one. You want longer odds, you want a horse nobody's heard of, and there isn't one.*"

THE NOTICE

Dusk, the twentieth day, at vespers. A man in a plain grey house-guard's jerkin, no band on the sleeve, nods to Grete, pins a sheet to the post by the bar, and **buys his own ale**. He drinks half and speaks to the room, not to them:

"*That's an honest job for honest folk. The Junker pays on arrival and I'll vouch for it. Anyone who can walk ten miles and sit a deck for two nights without being sick over the side — Erlenhof, first bell, day after tomorrow. Ask for Amtmann.*"

He finishes the ale and leaves. Grete watches him go and says, to nobody: "*Hessel Amtmann. He's never bought his own ale in this house in fifteen years. Every market day for a year he's paid a Vuurzward man at the well instead. Not this week.*"

Hand over Handout — The Notice.

Then read the table. Thirty marks is more than any of them owes Grete, and passage is worth another forty. It puts them on the quay the northern packet sails from, with the fare in hand and seventy short of arriving clear. It is also a great deal of money for walking a rich boy to a horse race. Let them talk. Let them not quite trust it. Don't help.

CLUES AVAILABLE HERE

- Amtmann buys his own ale tonight, and has stopped paying the Vuurzward man → **his debt**

PROOF

to the Vuurzwards is gone (Hessel sold the route)

- Tilo: the sergeant's wife was a Vuurzward → **Hessel and Vuurzward are connected**
- Tilo: the new saddle nobody sees → **the Junker is entering a horse**

SENSORY PALETTE

- **Sight:** grey slate, cream plaster, clan bands at shoulder height, Grete's chalk board
- **Sound:** cowbells in the meadows at all hours, the chapel bell, a fiddle played badly at vespers
- **Smell:** cheese, woodsmoke, wet wool, the smelters when the wind is west
- **Touch:** slate underfoot, cold even in summer
- **Taste:** small beer, thin and sour; rye bread hard enough to knock on

ALTERNATES & RE-HOOKS

- **Don't name the Halbritters before the notice.** "The grey house at the top of the hill" is enough. The name comes with the job.
- **The table refuses the job.** Adalinde finds them at the Rest that night with her own money and a straighter story, and comes with them. Otwin's men are now looking for *her*; see Scene 01 — Erlenhof.
- **Pregens.** The arrival table is the whole session zero. Don't skip it.

TRANSITION

- → Scene 01 — Erlenhof: first bell, the morning after next, they walk up the hill.

PROOF

SCENE 01 — ERLENHOF

PURPOSE

Hire them, and plant the lie where they can find it. The third wagon must not be handed over; it is there to be found.

ARRIVAL

The grey house sits at the top of the hill with its back to the mountains. The doorpost beside the gate is bare, old wood scrubbed pale by forty years of rain. Behind it the land opens into paddocks full of horses, and a woman in a grey riding coat walks the fence line with a bucket, not hurrying. Three wagons stand in the yard. The third is shuttered and rides low on its springs. A man in a house-guard's jerkin comes out to meet you before you reach the door, and steers you away from it.

To the table: "*The sergeant says the Junker is at the stable. Who looks at the boy, and who looks at the horses?*"

WHO IS HERE

- **Hessel Amtmann**, sergeant of the house guard. *Wants:* the debt gone and his hands clean. *Knows:* everything; he sold the route ten days ago. *Reacts:* answers a different question than the one asked; says "I couldn't spare a man" three different ways.
- **Corwin Halbritter**, *Junker*, 19. *Wants:* to be taken seriously once. *Knows:* the horse, the forged seal, the rented colors; not the leak. *Reacts:* talks past the end of his own sentences; goes quiet when someone competent questions the plan.
- **Adalinde Halbritter**, *Jungfer*, 24. *Wants:* to ride that mare at Duffkyyn, and will not say so. *Knows:* everything about the mare, nothing about the note. *Reacts:* says less than she knows and never less than the truth; watches which of them looks at the horses instead of the boy.
- **Maus**, in the third wagon, being quiet in the dark.

BEATS

AMTMANN, WALKING THEM OUT

"*You'll find the Junker enthusiastic. That's not a warning. He's nineteen. Answer what he asks and don't volunteer, and you'll get on.*"

If asked…	Amtmann says
Why the house guard isn't going	"*Six men. Four are cousins to the tollkeeper, and the tollkeeper is Herr Otwin's man to the bone. You see the difficulty.*" He never says what the difficulty is.
What's in the wagons	"*The Junker's baggage. He travels heavy. Nobles do.*" He looks at the third wagon while he says it.
Who else knows about the trip	"*Nobody. That's rather the point.*" This is the one lie he tells badly: **Insight DC 12** catches that he is frightened, not why.

CORWIN, THE HIRING

He comes out of the stable too fast, wiping his hands, talking before he has crossed the yard: "*You're the ones from the Rest. Good. It's a simple thing. You walk beside the wagon, you look like men who've killed someone, and in Schwartzenbruin I pay you. Ten miles to the water, two nights on a boat, and then it's the Derby. I'll want you sober at the quay. That's the only condition.*"

The players decide the terms.

Push	Corwin
Once	"*Forty, then. Forty. It's not — fine. Forty.*"
Twice, or ask for a share	"*A share of —* " He looks at the stable door. "*One part in five of whatever she — of whatever the trip earns. If it earns.*"

That slip is free: any player who catches it has **advantage on Insight** for the rest of the scene. Pressing for the share is the first thing that makes Adalinde look at them twice.

THE THIRD WAGON

Shuttered, bedded with straw, low on its springs, and it shifts when nothing is touching it. Asked what's in it, Corwin says "*Baggage,*" then "*My baggage,*" then (a third ask, or **Insight DC 13**) "*Why does everyone keep asking me that?*"

If they open it: straw, warmth, and a grey mare near enough to white at the flank, who turns her head and looks at them with enormous patience. Corwin folds at once and badly: "*All right. All right. She's a horse. She's* the *horse. If you walk away*

PROOF

now I understand. But you'd be walking away from forty marks, and I'd be walking to Schwartzenbruin alone, and I am going to Schwartzenbruin."

A party that opens the wagon in the first five minutes has not broken anything. Corwin folding early is a better Act 1, and Adalinde sizes them up sooner. **Leave it shut, and it opens itself at the bridge.**

ADALINDE AT THE FENCE

She does not come to them; they come to her, or they don't meet her.

"*You took the job, then.*" (Beat.) "*He told you it's luggage.*"

If asked…	Adalinde says
(They say yes, luggage)	"*It weighs nine hundredweight and it kicked the boards out of that wagon last Godsday. You may draw your own conclusions. I'd draw them before the bridge, myself.*"
Whose horse it is	"*The farm's.*" (A pause just long enough to notice.) "*I bred her. I broke her. Her name is Maus, and if anybody at Duffkyyn calls her that I'll know where they heard it.*"
Whether the plan will work	"*No.*" (If they wait:) "*But he's going anyway, and he's going alone if you don't. So.*" She hands the bucket to whoever is nearest, which is the first small test.
Whether she rides	"*I ride.*" That is the complete answer. **Note who asked**: that player has found the climax three scenes early and should get the payoff in Scene 7.
Her father	"*He's signing a remount contract in Schwartzenbruin at noon on Derby Day. Thirty head over three years. It's a good contract.*" She says *good contract* the way you'd say *good weather at a funeral*.

DEVELOPMENT

- The party is employed at 30 or 40 marks, with or without the one-in-five share. Record it; it decides the reward table.
- Hessel watches the party leave from the gate. He does not come.

CLUES AVAILABLE HERE

- The wagon rides low and shifts; Adalinde's nine hundredweight → **there is a racehorse in the third wagon**
- "*I ride.*" → **Adalinde should ride**
- Amtmann's bad lie → **Hessel is frightened of someone**

SENSORY PALETTE

- **Sight:** a bare doorpost, thirty horses in long morning light, a woman in grey with a bucket
- **Sound:** hooves on packed earth, a wagon spring creaking with nobody near it
- **Smell:** straw, horse, neatsfoot oil
- **Touch:** the warm side of the shuttered wagon
- **Taste:** dust from the yard

ALTERNATES & RE-HOOKS

- **The party refuses the job.** Adalinde finds them at the Rest that night with her own money and a straighter story, and comes along. This removes the Scene 7 rider problem and replaces it: Otwin's men are looking for *her*, and at post time the problem is Otwin, not Corwin.
- **The party takes the job and never looks.** Fine. The bridge reveals it.
- **A PC tries to tell Otwin.** He is in the house with his ledger and the gout. He hears them out, thanks them, and sends the writ an hour sooner. Run Scene 2 with Boedic already standing in the road.

TRANSITION

- → Scene 02 — The Erlen Bridge: the wagons roll at first bell; the road drops toward the river, and there are cows on it.

SCENE 02 — THE ERLEN BRIDGE

ART · Scene banner: the Erlen bridge (Art Brief §3)

PURPOSE

The first real decision, and the reveal if it hasn't happened. **This scene is built to be talked through.** A fight is legal and expensive.

ARRIVAL

The road drops toward the water and there are cows on it, forty or fifty head strung along the verge, with men in red-and-black walking beside them. Beyond them is a stone bridge, a toll house, and the road to the lake. One drover has been watching you come for a while. He is older than the rest, and he holds a folded paper the way you hold something you'd rather not have been given. He steps into the road, hands well away from his belt. "Morning. Would one of you be the Junker Halbritter?"

To the table: "*He hasn't asked you anything. He's asked the boy. Who answers for him?*"

WHO IS HERE

- **Boedic of the Meerijder**, drover. *Wants:* to obey a lawful writ and go home to his cows. *Knows:* the writ says hold the wagons and the Junker until the Ratsherr comes; it says nothing about the party. *Reacts:* explains himself, asks questions, apologizes while not moving.
- **Six Meerijder drovers** with cattle goads, and (APL 3–4) two mastiffs trained to hold cloth.
- **Old Hartwin**, 68, in the toll house. Will not fight; remembers faces.

BEATS

THE WRIT

"*I've a writ here from Ratsherr Halbritter. Ink's not dry; it came down on a pony an hour past. It says hold the wagons and hold the Junker until the Ratsherr comes himself.*" (He looks at the party, honestly puzzled.) "*It doesn't say a word about you lot. So I'd as soon you stood over there and had some bread while we sort it. Nobody wants a Fehde over a horse.*"

He says **horse**. If nobody has opened the wagon, that is the reveal, and Corwin's face does the rest.

The players decide whether to open the wagon in front of Boedic. He is an honest witness, which cuts both ways.

GETTING PAST — PICK ONE APPROACH, NOT A GAUNTLET

Any **one** of these ends the scene.

PROOF

Approach	Check	Boedic
Claim clan kinship (a plausible surname)	**Automatic**	He takes his hat off: "*Cousin. You should have led with that.*" He stands aside and tells his kin at the Flats a clansman was running a horse for the clanless. A favor *spent*.
The jurisdiction argument: Aerden's tolls, Aerden's council, a Halbritter family quarrel with no Meerijder interest in it	Persuasion DC 13, or **automatic** if the player makes the argument aloud	"*You're telling me I'm a Meerijder drover stood in the middle of a Halbritter family quarrel.*" (Beat.) "*Aye. That's about the size of it.*" He wants it on record that he is not happy.
Bribe	6 marks is his day-fee; he takes **12**, no roll	He counts it without looking at anyone. "*I was never here, and neither were you.*"
Forge a counter-writ	DC 15 with a forgery kit, DC 17 without	Failure: he sends a rider to Erlenhof, and Otwin comes at dusk
Spook the cattle across the road	Animal Handling DC 14	Buys a crossing, and they are now cattle thieves in a canton of stockmen
Sneak the wagons over at night	Stealth DC 13 (group)	Costs a day and the *Kortheim Maid*; see Alternates
Fight	—	See Encounter

IF THEY'RE HELD: OTWIN AT DUSK

This is a scene, not a wall. The cart comes at dusk with a lantern on the rail, and the old man in it doesn't get down, because getting down would cost him something. He looks at the third wagon, then at his son. "*Corwin.*" That's all. He waits.

Corwin, with nothing prepared: "*She's the best horse we've ever had and you're going to sell her to the levy.*"

Otwin: "*Yes. Thirty horses over three years, paid in silver, quarterly, by the canton. That is a future. A race is an afternoon. I have buried a wife and a son in this ground and I will not bury the farm for an afternoon.*"

The winning move is asking to see the ledger. He has it under the seat. Of course he does. Investigation DC 14, or automatic for a PC with trade or bookkeeping: the remount contract pays 90 marks a quarter, the tolls it is set against are worth 60, and **the place purse at Duffkyyn is 500**. Tell him that and he goes quiet. "*Five hundred. And if she loses?*" Any honest answer gets them past: Persuasion DC 13, with advantage if they showed him the number.

- **Win it:** "*Go on, then. Go. Tell my daughter — no. Tell her nothing. She'll have worked it out.*"
- **Lose it:** Otwin takes the mare home. At midnight the party reaches Osterschlauss to find Adalinde on the quay with the mare she led out of the barn an hour after her father brought it in: "*He put her in the near stall and went to bed. I have a key to the near stall. I've had it since I was twelve. Are you coming, or shall I find the boat myself?*"

Keep the writ. It names Otwin, and it is evidence later (Otwin's Writ).

ENCOUNTER (IF ANY)

APL	Creatures	Difficulty (4 PCs)
1	Boedic + 3 drovers	Deadly (1,500)
2	Boedic + 5 drovers	Deadly (1,900)
3	Boedic + 5 drovers + 2 mastiffs	Deadly (2,500)
4	Boedic + 5 drovers + 2 mastiffs	Deadly (2,500)

Boedic uses the **bandit captain** block reflavored; drovers are **thugs**; mastiffs hold, they don't bite. See Bestiary.

Terrain: a stone toll bridge three wagons wide, waist-high walls, a toll house at the near end (half cover), and thirty cattle on the road behind. The river is four feet deep and slow: a shove over the wall is 1d6 falling damage and a wet, furious drover, not a drowning. **The cattle are terrain:** any loud noise (a shout, a scream, a thunderous spell) sets them milling, and the road is difficult terrain for 2 rounds; everyone in it makes a **DC 11 Dexterity save or falls prone**. **Tactics:** round 1 they form a line across the bridge and do not advance. Boedic spends his first turn talking. They target the wagon team, not the party: the goal is to stop wheels. **Morale breaks at two drovers down:** "*Enough. Enough! Take the bloody bridge, and when the Ratsherr asks, you tell him I bled for it.*" **DM direction:** say it before initiative: **knocking out is free** (any melee attack), and **killing a clansman without a declared Fehde is murder**. A party that kills drovers has started a feud with the Meerijder and will meet it at the Flats. Most parties take the hint.

MINION PACK (JUST IN CASE)

Use this when the fight needs more bodies: a pack of 4–8 **Meerijder Drover** minions, built from the

PROOF

thug (MM p. 350), as Boedic's drovers, with the Brute Minion template at **APL 3**. More of Boedic's drovers come over the bridge rail. Overwhelm can push a PC off the bridge. Each minion is worth **175 XP**, and every four count as one creature for the encounter multiplier (04 — Minions). Add them four at a time and recheck the encounter's adjusted XP.

MEERIJDER DROVER, BRUTE MINION (CR 3 MINION, 175 XP)

Medium humanoid (human), neutral **Armor Class** 12 (leather armor) · **Hit Points** 1 (minion) · **Speed** 30 ft.

STR	DEX	CON	INT	WIS	CHA
15 (+2)	11 (+0)	14 (+2)	10 (+0)	10 (+0)	11 (+0)

Senses passive Perception 10 · **Languages** Common · **Challenge** 3 (175 XP)

Minion. If the minion takes any damage, it drops to 0 hit points. If it succeeds on a saving throw against an effect that would deal half damage on a success, it takes no damage instead.

Overwhelm (Brute). When the drover hits a creature with a melee attack, the target must succeed on a DC 13 Strength saving throw or be pushed 10 feet away or knocked prone (the drover's choice).

Actions ***Drover's Cudgel.*** *Melee Weapon Attack:* +4 to hit, reach 5 ft., one target. *Hit:* 14 bludgeoning damage.

At other APLs (change only these numbers):

APL	AC	Attack	DC	Damage	XP each
1	12	+3	13	8	50
2	12	+3	13	11	112
3 (built)	12	+4	13	14	175
4	13	+5	14	18	275

FGU Import (minion)

Paste into **NPCs → Import Text**, mode **2022 – Monsters of the Multiverse**.

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text Meerijder Drover, Brute Minion Medium humanoid (human), neutral Armor Class 12 (leather armor) Hit Points 1 (minion) Speed 30 ft. STR DEX CON INT WIS CHA 15 (+2) 11 (+0) 14 (+2) 10 (+0) 10 (+0) 11 (+0) Senses passive Perception 10 Languages Common Challenge 3 (175 XP) Proficiency Bonus +2 Minion. If the minion takes any damage, it drops to 0 hit points. If it succeeds on a saving throw against an effect that would deal half damage on a success, it takes no damage instead. Overwhelm (Brute). When the drover hits a creature with a melee attack, the target must succeed on a DC 13 Strength saving throw or be pushed 10 feet away or knocked prone (the drover's choice). Actions Drover's Cudgel. Melee Weapon Attack: +4 to hit, reach 5 ft., one target. Hit: 14 bludgeoning damage.
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DEVELOPMENT

- **Bloodless crossing** → the bridge commendation in the patron's letter. Say so at the table.
- **Drovers killed** → Fehde. Roodberg hears by Scene 5 (his attitude drops one step), and Boedic's kin are in the stable rows on Derby eve.
- **Clan kinship used** → Boedic's kin at the Flats know a clansman is running a horse for the clanless.
- **Held, then argued free** → Otwin's message for his daughter; Otwin arrives at the Flats on the morning packet anyway.

CLUES AVAILABLE HERE

- Boedic says *horse* → **there is a racehorse in the third wagon**
- Otwin's ledger → **second place is enough** (500 against 400)
- Otwin's Writ → Otwin knew by dawn; who told him? (Hartwin, about the chain-dragging stranger)

SENSORY PALETTE

- **Sight:** red-and-black sleeves, a folded paper, cattle strung along the verge, the toll house's slate roof
- **Sound:** cowbells, the river under the arch, Boedic's patient voice
- **Smell:** cattle, crushed grass, river water
- **Touch:** warm stone on the parapet
- **Taste:** the bread Boedic offers, if they take it

ALTERNATES & RE-HOOKS

- **A three-day hold** misses the Derby. Don't let it happen: Otwin comes at dusk on the first day.
- **A one-day hold** (night crossing, or a failed forgery) misses the *Maid* and catches the slower *Agal Wind*: they arrive Day 4 at dusk, Scenes 5 and 6 squeeze into Derby eve, and nobody gets a long rest before the race. Late costs; it doesn't end the game.
- **Old Hartwin**, asked, will say a stranger in a dark Traft coat dragged a surveyor's chain across his bridge yesterday, counting links. "*Kettenhaus man. They measure what they mean to take*." (Color for later; it changes nothing today.)

TRANSITION

- → Scene 03 — Osterschlauss: the road comes over a rise, and the lake is just there.

PROOF

ACT 2 — LAKE QUAG

SCENE 03 — OSTERSCHLAUSS

PURPOSE

One clean problem-solving beat; a breather with teeth. Get sixteen hands of grey aboard a passage booked for one man and his baggage. This is the moment Corwin stops being the employer.

ARRIVAL

> *The road comes over a rise and the lake is just there, filling the whole of the north: grey-green, flat, with the far shore only a smudge that might be cloud. Osterschlauss is a hundred houses and a stone quay. Tied up against the quay is a fat little cog with one mast and her name painted on the stern, Kortheim Maid. At the head of the gangway stands a clerk with a roll of paper, writing down everything that goes aboard.*

To the table: "*Corwin has stopped at the foot of the gangway. He's looking at you. Who goes up first?*"

WHO IS HERE

- **Captain Marda Vosk**, master of the *Kortheim Maid*. *Wants:* declared cargo and paid fare. *Knows:* what selling a horse to the Rhennee means on the Flats. *Reacts:* asks nothing about weight that's on the roll and everything about weight that isn't; prices everything, including silence.
- **Ebbo Kühn**, the Hafenmeister's clerk, with the *Frachtrolle*. *Wants:* every entry in its column. *Knows:* that a roll read aloud in Aerden is a roll Otwin hears. *Reacts:* asks about anything undeclared, takes a bribe and asks why, and remembers. The roll is read aloud in Aerden market every Godsday, which is why Corwin couldn't book the horse: booking her would have been telling his father.
- **Corwin Halbritter**, out of plan.

BEATS

CORWIN RUNS OUT OF PLAN

He has been quiet since the bridge. At the foot of the gangway he says, to nobody in particular: "*I had it worked out as far as the boat. I did not — the boat was the plan. What do we do?*"

From here on Corwin asks the party what to do, and means it.

VOSK

"*Forty marks a head, Osterschlauss to Schwartzenbruin, two nights, and that's what's on the Frachtrolle.*" She looks past them at the third wagon for exactly one breath. "*Nine hundredweight of luggage is not on the Frachtrolle. Now. I can be paid to write slowly. I cannot be paid to be surprised. Which is it going to be?*"

- **Honest with her:** she laughs. "*A racehorse. That's the first interesting thing to come down that road in a year. Twenty marks, and she goes in the deck stall, and if the Hafenmeister asks, she's breeding stock going to a Roodberg farm. Which she may as well be.*"
- **Hiding it entirely:** "*You understand I have to write something.*"

GETTING HER ABOARD — THE PLAYERS DECIDE THE METHOD

Take one plan, set one DC, resolve it.

Approach	Check
Bribe the clerk	10 marks, no roll; he asks why, and remembers
Forge a roll entry ("breeding stock, Roodberg")	DC 15 with forgery kit, DC 17 without
Load at the far end of the quay at the wrong bell	Stealth DC 12 (group)
Pay Vosk to write slowly	Persuasion DC 14, or 20 marks
Distract the clerk	Deception or Performance DC 13

Failure is not refusal. The mare goes aboard either way. Failure means the entry goes on the roll, and the roll is read aloud in Aerden.

PROOF

DEVELOPMENT

- **The entry went on the roll** → Otwin knows by Day 3 and arrives in Schwartzenbruin a full day early. He is **waiting in the stewards' tent** in Scene 5, and at post time he is already in the row.
- **No trail** → Otwin and Adalinde come in on the morning packet on Derby Day, as planned.
- The deck stall is at the bow against the starboard rail, eight feet by ten, canvas-roofed, with the deck's one lantern hung just aft of it. Note who sleeps nearest it.

CLUES AVAILABLE HERE

- Vosk's price list → **Vosk can be trusted to say what things cost** (she'll price the Rhennee offer honestly in Scene 4)

SENSORY PALETTE

- **Sight:** the lake filling the north, a one-masted cog, a clerk's wet pen
- **Sound:** gulls, a gangway creaking under hooves, the clerk reading back an entry
- **Smell:** pitch, fish, lake water
- **Touch:** a rope burn from the halter as the mare balks at the gangway
- **Taste:** spray

ALTERNATES & RE-HOOKS

- **They missed the *Maid*** (a one-day hold at the bridge): the slower *Agal Wind* sails next morning. Its master takes 50 marks and asks no questions at all. Krul is aboard the *Agal Wind* instead. Arrival is Day 4 at dusk.
- **Adalinde came instead of Corwin** (they refused the job): she has the coin and does the talking; the party handles the clerk.

TRANSITION

- → Scene 04 — Two Nights on the Quag: lines cast off, and the shore slides past on the right hand all afternoon.

PROOF

SCENE 04 — TWO NIGHTS ON THE QUAG

ART · Scene banner: the Rhennee barges (Art Brief §3)

PURPOSE

The adventure's breathing room, its biggest temptation, and its first fight. The party leaves knowing Vuurzward's name and the phrase *ten days*.

ARRIVAL

> *The shore slides past on the right hand all afternoon and never comes closer or goes further. Every captain on this lake keeps land in sight. Out in the middle there is grey fog that doesn't lift. There are sixteen passengers: a cheese factor and his wife, two Roodberg grooms already drunk, a woman traveling alone who reads, and a thin man near the mast who has said nothing to anyone and was aboard before you were.*

To the table: "*Two nights, sixteen strangers, one canvas stall. Who's sleeping next to the horse?*"

The thin man is Anse Krul. Do not point at him. Include him every time you list the passengers.

WHO IS HERE

- **Anse Krul**, farrier. *Wants:* his forty marks. *Knows:* Vuurzward's man paid him, and gave him the boat and the day ten days back; not who told them. *Reacts:* runs before he fights; cornered, names his employer without much pressing.
- **Captain Marda Vosk**. Knows the price of everything, including the Rhennee offer.
- **The Rhennee**: three long barges, and **Zinka of the Kestrel** at the rail, who knows the mare's stable name. *Wants:* the mare, for someone she won't name. *Knows:* only that she was told to watch this boat. *Reacts:* makes the 600-mark offer once, reads a fortune for anyone who crosses the plank, and lets the barges drop back if refused.
- **Corwin Halbritter**, talking too much on the first evening.

BEATS

EVENING ONE (10 MIN)

The boat, the passengers, Corwin talking. Seed Krul as a face. A PC who knows horses notices the thin man has farrier's hands (scarred, a burn across one palm) and that he looks at the deck stall the way a buyer looks at a sale ring.

EVENING TWO — THE RHENNEE (15 MIN)

> *Three long barges come out of the dusk without a sound, lantern-light strung along their awnings. They don't hail. They match your speed forty feet off the port rail, as though they had been going that way anyway. Someone over there is playing something with strings. A woman comes to the rail, looks straight at your deck stall, and says in a voice that carries too well across the water: "That's a good little mouse you've got there."*

Nobody on the boat told her that name. She is Zinka, of the barge *Kestrel*. There is a card game on the afterdeck (lose four kleinmarks, win four, it doesn't matter) and a fortune for anyone who crosses the plank.

The offer, made to whoever seems to be in charge, which by now isn't Corwin: "*Six hundred marks. Tonight, in coin, and you can count it on your own deck before you hand her over. You look like people who could use six hundred marks.*"

If asked…	She says
Why	"*Because she's worth it, and you know she's worth it, or you wouldn't have her in a canvas box in the dark.*"
Pressed harder	"*I was told to watch this boat. I wasn't told why, and I've stopped asking.*" Deliver it and move on.

Vosk, if asked: "*Clan houses don't sell bloodstock to bargefolk. Not* don't like to. *Don't. Do that, and the boy's name is worth less than the wagon it came in. Now. It's not my name, and it's not my six hundred marks.*"

The players decide. Six hundred marks clears the note with two hundred over, which Corwin splits with the party, and it finishes the Halbritters on the Flats for good. It is a real choice with a real price. **Let them take it.**

THE SMALL HOURS (15 MIN)

> *Something is wrong with the sound of the deck. A horse standing quiet makes a particular noise: a shift, a breath, a hoof set down and settled. What comes from the deck stall now is a hoof being lifted, held, and set down wrong.*

Run the encounter. Krul needs **three uninterrupted rounds** in the stall. Mark them where the players can see.

Krul, cornered: "*Easy. Easy. Look at my hands. There's a knife in them and it's four inches long and it's for hooves. A nail an inch too deep, that's all. She walks fine. She runs like she's on coals. Nobody dies. That's the trade.*"

Krul, questioned: "*Vuurzward's man. Forty marks, half up front, paid me in Osterschlauss.*" (The shrug is what makes players want to hit him.) "*He gave me the boat and the day ten days back. Ten days, friend. She wasn't even loaded yet. So don't look at me like that. Somebody in that house talks.*"

The players decide Krul's fate: hand him to Vosk (she puts him ashore at the next landing, and he walks to Schwartzenbruin for Scene 6); keep him bound aboard (a witness for the stewards' tent and for Roodberg); or let him go for the name.

ENCOUNTER (IF ANY)

APL	Creatures	Difficulty (4 PCs)
1	Krul alone; flees at half HP	Medium (200)
2	Krul + 1 deckhand	Medium (450)
3	Krul + 2 deckhands, one with a hand crossbow	Medium (800)
4	Krul + 2 deckhands, one with a hand crossbow	Easy (800)

Krul is a **spy**; the bribed deckhands are **thugs** with 20 HP. See Bestiary.

Terrain: a lake cog, 60 feet stem to stern, one mast; the deck stall at the bow against the starboard rail, with the deck's one lantern hung just aft of it. **Darkness:** Krul has shuttered the lantern to a slit (dim light within 10 feet, darkness beyond); his eyes are adjusted, the party's are not. Unshuttering it is an action, or a bonus action for a PC adjacent to it, and lights 20 feet, which ends his advantage in the dark. **A moving deck:** any creature that Dashes, is shoved, or takes a reaction attack makes an **Acrobatics DC 10 check or falls prone**. **The rail:** a shove past it means the lake, **Athletics DC 12** to swim, and the *Maid* takes three rounds to come about. Nobody drowns unless a player insists. **Fire is not an option:** one open flame near the canvas, and Vosk puts the party ashore forty miles from Schwartzenbruin with two days to go. Say so if anyone reaches for a torch. **Tactics:** round 1 Krul tries to finish the job. From round 2 he runs, over the rail if cornered; he can swim. The deckhands are bribed, not loyal, and surrender the moment Krul goes down or bolts. **DM direction:** this is a clock, not a slugfest. Interrupting Krul at any point resets the count to zero; three marks drops the mare one Condition step whatever happens to Krul afterward. Detection: **passive Perception 13** if someone is on watch on deck; **Perception DC 15** from below decks; a PC who knows horses has advantage and notices one round earlier. Full rules in The Mare, the Clock and the Cord.

MINION PACK (JUST IN CASE)

Use this when the fight needs more bodies: a pack of 4–8 **Bribed Deckhand** minions, built from the **thug** (MM p. 350), as Krul's bribed crew, with the Skirmisher Minion template at **APL 3**. More bribed crew come up from below decks. Each minion is worth **175 XP**, and every four count as one creature for the encounter multiplier (04 — Minions). Add them four at a time and recheck the encounter's adjusted XP.

PROOF

BRIBED DECKHAND, SKIRMISHER MINION (CR 3 MINION, 175 XP)

Medium humanoid (human), neutral **Armor Class** 13 (leather armor) · **Hit Points** 1 (minion) · **Speed** 40 ft.

STR	DEX	CON	INT	WIS	CHA
15 (+2)	11 (+0)	14 (+2)	10 (+0)	10 (+0)	11 (+0)

Senses passive Perception 10 · **Languages** Common · **Challenge** 3 (175 XP)

Minion. If the minion takes any damage, it drops to 0 hit points. If it succeeds on a saving throw against an effect that would deal half damage on a success, it takes no damage instead.

Hit and Run (Skirmisher). The deckhand doesn't provoke opportunity attacks when it moves out of the reach of a creature it attacked this turn.

Actions ***Belaying Pin.*** *Melee Weapon Attack:* +4 to hit, reach 5 ft., one target. *Hit:* 9 bludgeoning damage.

At other APLs (change only these numbers):

APL	AC	Attack	DC	Damage	XP each
1	13	+3	13	5	50
2	13	+3	13	7	112
3 (built)	13	+4	13	9	175
4	14	+5	14	12	275

FGU Import (minion)

Paste into **NPCs → Import Text**, mode **2022 – Monsters of the Multiverse**.

```
text Bribed Deckhand, Skirmisher Minion Medium humanoid (human), neutral Armor Class 13 (leather armor) Hit Points 1 (minion) Speed 40 ft. STR DEX CON INT WIS CHA 15 (+2) 11 (+0) 14 (+2) 10 (+0) 10 (+0) 11 (+0) Senses passive Perception 10 Languages Common Challenge 3 (175 XP) Proficiency Bonus +2 Minion. If the minion takes any damage, it drops to 0 hit points. If it succeeds on a saving throw against an effect that would deal half damage on a success, it takes no damage instead. Hit and Run (Skirmisher). The deckhand doesn't provoke opportunity attacks when it moves out of the reach of a creature it attacked this turn. Actions Belaying Pin. Melee Weapon Attack: +4 to hit, reach 5 ft., one target. Hit: 9 bludgeoning damage.
```

DEVELOPMENT

- **Krul stopped or captured** → the watch commendation in the patron's letter; Maus stays **Sound**.
- **No one on watch** → no roll. Krul got his three rounds. Maus is sound to look at and **Sore** to run, and Adalinde (or the PC who knows horses) says so plainly at dawn. Act 3 has a clock on it. This is a real branch, not a punishment.
- **The mare sold** → 600 marks on deck. Maus is Otwin's horse, so Corwin selling her is a second crime on top of the seal; the Rhennee don't care. If Adalinde is aboard (the decline path), she refuses flatly, and the sale can only happen over her, which makes it theft. Run the short Act 3 in the Alternates of Scene 05 — The Stewards' Tent and Scene 07 — Post Time; cut Scene 6.
- **Krul kept aboard** → he can be produced before Roodberg in Scene 5.

CLUES AVAILABLE HERE

- Krul: "*Vuurzward's man. Forty marks.*" → **Vuurzward paid to stop the mare**
- Krul: "*Ten days back.*" → **someone in the house sold the route**
- The Rhennee woman knows the stable name → *(dangling: who wanted the mare?)*
- Adalinde, if asked about the race: "*She won't beat the Roodberg colt. She'll beat most of the rest.*" → **second place is enough**

PROOF

SENSORY PALETTE

- **Sight:** the shore always on the right hand, grey fog to the north, lantern-light along three barge awnings
- **Sound:** strings from the barges, cards slapped on a cask, a hoof lifted and set down wrong
- **Smell:** pitch, wet canvas, horse
- **Touch:** the deck moving under bare feet in the dark
- **Taste:** the Rhennee's cooking, if anyone crosses the plank

ALTERNATES & RE-HOOKS

- **Nobody talks to the Rhennee.** The woman calls the offer across the water anyway, to Corwin, who looks at the party.
- **The party catches Krul on the first night.** He has a partner among the deckhands; the second night's attempt comes from the bribed deckhand alone (Sabotage Clock as written).
- **Krul goes over the rail and escapes.** He is in the stable rows on Derby eve (APL 3–4 rows).

TRANSITION

- → **The lake-gate, dusk on Richfest 2.** The *Maid* comes in under Schwartzenbruin's lake-gate, and the patrol meets every boat: **Sergeant Ruwen Hask** steps onto the planks with a lantern before the boat is tied, and a clerk opens a ledger. "*Business. Lodging. Company.*" Every answer goes down; a horse that came aboard off the roll goes into this ledger instead. It changes nothing; it is how the city works (see SP-PBS-03-The-Red-Cord). Lodging near the Flats, and a short night.
- → Scene 05 — The Stewards' Tent: the morning of Richfest 3, and the Flats gate.

PROOF

ACT 3 — THE DUFFKYYN FLATS

SCENE 05 — THE STEWARDS' TENT

ART · Scene banner: the Duffkyyn Flats (Art Brief §3)

PURPOSE

The trap closes, and the antagonist makes a reasonable offer. The party leaves knowing the entry is one complaint from being scratched, having met Vuurzward and heard his offer. **Do not resolve the sponsor problem here**; it is Scene 7's fuel.

ARRIVAL

Schwartzenbruin is twenty-six thousand people in slate and timber under a Rathaus tower with a clock on it. Outside the walls the Duffkyyn Flats are a city of their own: striped pavilions in clan colors, cook-fires, a sale ring, and beyond it all the long green curve of the course. At the Flats gate a boy takes your sword, threads a red cord through hilt and scabbard both, knots it, and presses a wax seal onto the knot. "Landfrieden. Derby peace. Cut it and you hang. Enjoy the races."

To the table: "*The Roodberg pavilion is the biggest on the Flats, and the stewards' tent is beside it. Corwin is already walking toward it. Does anyone stop him first?*"

WHO IS HERE

- **Steward Alric Roodberg**, chief steward of the Duffkyyn. *Wants:* the Derby run properly. *Knows:* the rules by heart, and that half his register is ghosts. *Reacts:* starts **Indifferent**; not bribable with money, very bribable with correct papers. One step worse if the party spilled blood on the road.
- **Sivert Vuurzward**, hat in hand the entire time. *Wants:* Erlenhof and the mare. *Knows:* the seal is forged; a party member's debt, which he has bought. *Reacts:* never threatens, never lies; he leaves things out. Makes his offer to *them*, not to Corwin.
- **Benno**, the stewards' boy, who ties the cords at the gate and runs the stewards' messages. *Wants:* to be noticed by Roodberg. *Knows:* where everyone in the book is lodged. *Reacts:* answers any question about the rules, exactly.
- **Jorick Weisel**, the broker, leaving by another flap as they come in.
- **Corwin Halbritter**, three feet away, waiting to be told.

BEATS

STEWARD ROODBERG

"*Ostvelt.*" He turns the register around and taps a line. "*Ostvelt green. The Ostvelts have been dead thirty years, Junker. I don't mind that. Half this book is ghosts. What I mind is that the man who signed for those ghosts is not standing in front of me.*"

If they…	Roodberg
Ask what he needs	"*A living sponsor of record, in this tent, with a hand on this book, before the third bell tomorrow. That's the rule. It's the only thing standing between this race and a field of horses owned by nobody.*" And: "*Whoever signs names the rider. That's the other rule.*"
Try money	He writes in the margin. "*I'll pretend that was for the widows' fund.*" Attitude drops one step, and he is now watching them.
Ask for a substitute sponsor	Persuasion DC 17, or DC 12 with a Roodberg or Meerijder name vouching. Success here only tells them it *can* be done; nobody signs tonight.
Ask to see the odds-book	Give it freely; this is the clue (below). Investigation DC 13 to spot the anomaly, or automatic for a PC with trade or bookkeeping.
Produce Krul as a witness	Roodberg listens. With the odds-book account as well, he will bar Vuurzward's own horses from the Derby: a real blow, and it does nothing to the note.

He closes the book: "*Find him by the third bell, or I strike the line.*"

THE ODDS-BOOK

Ostvelt Grey opened at twenty to one this morning and has shortened to fourteen, which is normal enough for a horse nobody has seen. What isn't normal is the column beside it: somebody has been laying money **against** her, steadily, in small amounts, **from an account opened ten days ago. The account is in the name of Vuurzward.** The purses are posted on the stewards' board: first 1,000 marks, **second 500**, third 200.

VUURZWARD

He comes to them. "*You'll be the ones who came up from Aerden with the boy. Sivert Vuurzward. I lend money, mostly. I breed a little.*"

The offer: "*I hold a paper with Herr Otwin Halbritter's seal on it. Four hundred marks against the Erlen tolls. The paper says what it says. I would rather not read it aloud in the Rathaus; it would embarrass a family I have no quarrel with, in front of people who'd enjoy it. So. Give me the mare, and the paper goes in the fire, and the farm stands, and everyone goes home.*" He puts his hat on. "*Tell the boy that. He'll hear it better from you than from me.*"

If…	Vuurzward
Accused of hiring Krul	"*I don't know the name.*" The only lie he tells, and he tells it perfectly: **Insight DC 18**.
Asked why the mare and not the money	"*Because I've seen her mother run.*" The truest thing anyone says in the adventure, and it costs him nothing.
Asked straight whether someone in the house sold him the route	"*I don't lie, scholar. Ask me something else.*"
Threatened	He looks at the red cord on the hilt, then at the man wearing it. "*The Schultheiss of this city is my cousin. I mention it only so nobody wastes an afternoon.*"
A PC carries a debt	In front of the others: "*Oh, and I bought your paper from a house in Krestible last month. Six marks and a bit. It's nothing. I only mention it so you don't hear it from someone less polite.*" He never mentions it again.

The players decide: the offer, and what to tell Corwin.

DEVELOPMENT

- **Offer taken** → Corwin's yes comes if the party tells him to give it. The mare goes to Vuurzward at Derby-evening prices tomorrow; the farm stands. Skip to Scene 08 — The Sale Ring after a short Scene 7.
- **Krul plus the odds-book before Roodberg** → Vuurzward's own entries are barred. He tips his hat and leaves the Flats. The note still stands.
- **The entry went on the roll in Scene 3** → **Otwin is already here**, sitting in the corner of the tent with his ledger. He says nothing. Corwin sees him.
- **Drovers were killed** → a PC is recognized by name at the gate; Roodberg starts **Hostile**.

CLUES AVAILABLE HERE

- Roodberg's rules → **whoever signs the book names the rider**
- The odds-book account → **Vuurzward paid to stop the mare**; opened **ten days ago** → **the route was sold**
- The posted purses → **second place is enough**
- Vuurzward's non-denial → **someone in the house sold the route**
- Weisel leaving by another flap → **the sponsor has run**

PROOF

SENSORY PALETTE

- **Sight:** striped pavilions, a register of dead houses' colors, a red cord and a wax seal on every hilt
- **Sound:** a sale-ring auctioneer's singsong, horses being walked, a pen scratching in the margin
- **Smell:** trodden grass, cook-fires, horse sweat, ink
- **Touch:** the wax seal, still warm
- **Taste:** Derby beer, stronger than Aerden's

ALTERNATES & RE-HOOKS

- **The party hunts Weisel tonight** instead of tomorrow. Move the Tanner's Rest beat from Scene 7 here; it becomes a whole scene of leaning on a coward, and Scene 7 opens with the book already signed or Weisel already gone.
- **The party never asks for the odds-book.** Roodberg mentions it himself if a PC says *Vuurzward*: "*Funny. That name's in my other book, too.*"
- **Nobody carries a debt.** Vuurzward makes the same offer without the aside.
- **The mare was sold to the Rhennee** (Scene 4). Run this scene short (15 minutes). Roodberg strikes the Ostvelt line: no horse, no entry. Vuurzward has already heard where she went; he finds Corwin within the hour and calls in the note at once. The 400 from the sale clears it, and he takes the coin with perfect courtesy: "*A pity. I had wanted the mare.*" The party's 200 is safe; their afternoon is free. Cut Scene 06 — The Stable Rows.

TRANSITION

- → Scene 06 — The Stable Rows: Derby eve, lanterns between the pavilions, and Corwin asking to stand the first watch.

PROOF

SCENE 06 — THE STABLE ROWS

ART · Scene banner: the stable rows (Art Brief §3)

PURPOSE

The adventure's one real fight, in terrain that makes fighting stupid. Settle the mare's Condition before the scene ends: Sound, Sore or Lame. **Whether the party wins is not the question.**

ARRIVAL

Derby eve. The rows run between the pavilions: forty stalls under one long roof, forty horses shifting and blowing in the dark, a lantern every twenty feet turning everything orange. It smells of straw, ammonia, neatsfoot oil and money. Down at the far end, past the Roodberg strings, a lantern that was hanging is now being carried. It has stopped in front of a stall that isn't theirs.

To the table: "*Your blades are corded and sealed. There are pitchforks in the rack, buckets at the post, and a lantern-pole at every third stall. What do you pick up?*"

WHO IS HERE

- **Vuurzward bravos** (2–4), Vuurzward green under plain cloaks, cords already cut. *Want:* the mare disabled and themselves gone. *Know:* Herr Sivert said nobody gets hurt. *React:* fight to disable and withdraw; morale breaks at half; they will help drag the fallen clear.
- **Anse Krul**, at APL 3–4, if he is free (escaped, put ashore by Vosk, or let go).
- **Corwin Halbritter**, who wants to stand the watch himself.
- **Forty horses**, who will kill whoever is standing when they go.

BEATS

CORWIN AND THE WATCH

Before dark, Corwin asks: "*Let me stand it.*" If anyone objects: "*It's my horse and my lie. Let me stand one watch like a man instead of a — let me stand one watch.*"

He has 11 hit points and will do something brave. **The players decide** whether to let him. If he stands the first watch alone, the bravos come on his watch, and he shouts before he does anything else, which is the bravest thing he could do.

THE PEACE-BOND

Say this at the top of round one, out loud, with the list (it saves six minutes of questions):

Improvised weapon	Damage	Note
Pitchfork	1d6 piercing	Reach
Lantern-pole	1d6 bludgeoning	Fire risk: see the Spook die
Water bucket	1d4 bludgeoning	Shove attempt at advantage
Hoof pick	1d4 piercing	Finesse
Saddle girth / lead rope	—	Grapple at advantage; restrains on a success
Stall door	—	Half cover, or shove a target prone
Feed sack	1d4 bludgeoning	Heavy; disadvantage on the next attack

Unarmed strikes, monk features, natural weapons and spells are unaffected, so the characters who don't usually shine in a stand-up fight shine here.

If a player cuts their cord and draws, let them. It works. The stewards' men arrive in 1d4 rounds, and the cost lands in Scene 7: Roodberg strikes the Ostvelt line on the spot unless the party can produce a very good reason. A real cost at the worst time is better than a refusal.

PROOF

THE SPOOK DIE

Track it in the open, starting at 0. Full rules in The Mare, the Clock and the Cord. - **+1:** a shout, a body hitting a stall wall, a lantern dropped or swung, a horse taking damage, a stall door left open. **+2:** any fire. - **−1:** a PC spends an action calming horses (**Animal Handling DC 12**). - **At 3:** the horses scream. Disadvantage on Perception in the row; Maus needs **Animal Handling DC 13** or she is unusable in Scene 7's opening minutes. - **At 5: stampede.** Everyone in the row makes a **DC 13 Dexterity save**: 7 (2d6) bludgeoning on a failure, half on a success. The row is difficult terrain for 3 rounds. A creature at 0 HP takes an automatic 2d6 unless someone drags it clear, and the bravos will help drag.

A party that grasps the die fights half this encounter with buckets and voices, which is exactly right.

WHAT THE BRAVOS SAY

"*Nobody's here for you. Walk down the other end and count to five hundred.*" At half strength, seeing the horses start: "*Down! Get him down and get him out, they're going —* "

ENCOUNTER (IF ANY)

APL	Creatures	Difficulty (4 PCs)
1	2 bravos	Hard (300)
2	3 bravos	Hard (600)
3	4 bravos + Krul (if he is free)	Hard (1,200)
4	4 bravos + Krul (if he is free)	Medium (1,200)

Bravos are **thugs** with cudgels and saps. Without Krul at APL 3–4, the encounter is Medium (800). See Bestiary.

Terrain: rows a wagon wide, stalls on both sides, a lantern every twenty feet, a lantern-pole at every third stall, a pitchfork rack and a water trough at the near end. Maus is in the fourteenth stall on the left, about two-thirds down, past the Roodberg strings. **Tactics:** the bravos start at the far end of the row and spend round 1 cutting a stall rope, so a bad initiative can't end the scene on the first turn. Two go for the mare while the rest hold the row. They need **three uninterrupted rounds** at her stall (the Sabotage Clock, as on the boat). They disable and withdraw; nobody wants a dead man on the Flats. **DM direction:** settle the mare's Condition before the scene ends. Interrupting the clock resets it.

MINION PACK (JUST IN CASE)

Use this when the fight needs more bodies: a pack of 4–8 **Vuurzward Bravo** minions, built from the **thug** (MM p. 350), as the Vuurzward bravos, with the Controller Minion template at **APL 3**. More bravos slip out between the stalls. Each minion is worth **175 XP**, and every four count as one creature for the encounter multiplier (04 — Minions). Add them four at a time and recheck the encounter's adjusted XP.

VUURZWARD BRAVO, CONTROLLER MINION (CR 3 MINION, 175 XP)

Medium humanoid (human), neutral evil **Armor Class** 13 (leather armor) · **Hit Points** 1 (minion) · **Speed** 30 ft.

STR	DEX	CON	INT	WIS	CHA
15 (+2)	11 (+0)	14 (+2)	10 (+0)	10 (+0)	11 (+0)

Senses passive Perception 10 · **Languages** Common · **Challenge** 3 (175 XP)

Minion. If the minion takes any damage, it drops to 0 hit points. If it succeeds on a saving throw against an effect that would deal half damage on a success, it takes no damage instead.

Actions ***Cudgel.*** *Melee Weapon Attack:* +4 to hit, reach 5 ft., one target. *Hit:* 5 bludgeoning damage.

Sap (Controller). In place of its attack, the bravo targets one creature it can see within 60 feet of it. The target must succeed on a DC 13 Wisdom saving throw or, until the end of its next turn, it can't take reactions, dazed by a sap to the skull.

At other APLs (change only these numbers):

APL	AC	Attack	DC	Damage	XP each
1	13	+3	13	3	50
2	13	+3	13	4	112
3 (built)	13	+4	13	5	175
4	14	+5	14	6	275

FGU Import (minion)

Paste into **NPCs → Import Text**, mode **2022 – Monsters of the Multiverse**. `text Vuurzward Bravo, Controller Minion Medium humanoid (human), neutral evil Armor Class 13 (leather armor) Hit Points 1 (minion) Speed 30 ft. STR DEX CON INT WIS CHA 15 (+2) 11 (+0) 14 (+2) 10 (+0) 10 (+0) 11 (+0) Senses passive Perception 10 Languages Common Challenge 3 (175 XP) Proficiency Bonus +2 Minion. If the minion takes any damage, it drops to 0 hit points. If it succeeds on a saving throw against an effect that would deal half damage on a success, it takes no damage instead. Actions Cudgel. Melee Weapon Attack: +4 to hit, reach 5 ft., one target. Hit: 5 bludgeoning damage. Sap (Controller). In place of its attack, the bravo targets one creature it can see within 60 feet of it. The target must succeed on a DC 13 Wisdom saving throw or, until the end of its next turn, it can't take reactions, dazed by a sap to the skull.`

DEVELOPMENT

- **Clock never filled** → Maus keeps her Condition from the boat.
- **Clock filled** → Maus drops one step (Sound → Sore; Sore → Lame).
- **A bravo dragged clear by a PC** → "*Herr Sivert said nobody gets hurt.*" The last-resort clue.
- **A cord cut and a blade drawn** → the stewards' men in 1d4 rounds; Roodberg strikes the line in Scene 7 unless the party has a very good reason.
- **Boedic's kin are here** if drovers died at the bridge: two Meerijder drovers in the next row, who watch and do nothing, which is its own message.

CLUES AVAILABLE HERE

- Vuurzward green under the cloaks; cords already cut → **Vuurzward paid to stop the mare**
- "*Herr Sivert said nobody gets hurt*" → last resort for the same

SENSORY PALETTE

- **Sight:** orange lantern-light moving where it shouldn't, forty heads turning at once
- **Sound:** horses blowing, a stall rope parting, a scream that isn't human
- **Smell:** straw, ammonia, neatsfoot oil, lamp oil
- **Touch:** a pitchfork shaft worn smooth, the heat of a frightened horse against a stall door
- **Taste:** dust kicked up from the straw

ALTERNATES & RE-HOOKS

- **The party never sets a watch.** No roll: the bravos get their three rounds and Maus drops one step. Adalinde finds it at dawn and says so.
- **Krul was captured on the boat.** The bravos come alone. If Krul is with the party, he recognizes the bravos and names them.
- **The party moves the mare** to another stall or out of the rows. The bravos search: give the party a free round of surprise when they find the wrong stall.

TRANSITION

- → Scene 07 — Post Time: morning, the bell for the second race, and a packet coming in from the east.

PROOF

SCENE 07 — POST TIME

ART · Half-column: post time (Art Brief §3)

PURPOSE

The whole adventure. Twenty minutes to the third bell, and three things are true: Corwin can't ride well enough to win and now knows it; Adalinde is standing in the row in riding boots she hasn't explained; the book is unsigned and the nomination is Corwin's. **Neither sibling will raise it. The party has to say it.**

ARRIVAL

> *Derby Day. The stands are full, the bell for the second race has gone, and the course is a green mile with a crowd four deep along its rail. The morning packet has come in. Otwin Halbritter stands at the end of the row with two house men, looking at the mare, not his son. Adalinde is beside the stall in riding boots. A steward's boy puts his head round the post: "Ostvelt Grey. The book's still not signed. Whoever signs names the rider. Third bell."*

Now stop talking. Let the table look at it. If a player asked Adalinde in Scene 1 whether she rides, she looks at that player, not at Corwin, when the steward's boy, Benno, speaks.

WHO IS HERE

- **Corwin Halbritter**. *Wants:* to be taken seriously. *Knows:* he can't win. *Reacts:* won't offer the ride.
- **Adalinde Halbritter**. *Wants:* to ride. *Knows:* she can place. *Reacts:* won't ask.
- **Otwin Halbritter**, here for the noon signing and staying for the race. *Wants:* the farm to outlive his children. *Reacts:* says nothing yet.
- **Jorick Weisel**, five minutes away at The Tanner's Rest, drinking.
- **Steward Alric Roodberg** and his book.

BEATS

IF THEY RAISE THE RIDER QUESTION

Corwin, after a silence that should be allowed to be uncomfortable: "*She's better than me. She's always been better than me. Everyone here knows it. I knew it in the yard when I was twelve and I've spent seven years* — " He stops. He turns to his sister, and this is the first grown-up sentence of his life: "*Linde. Will you ride her.*"

Adalinde: "*Yes.*" She is already taking the silks out of his hands. "*Give me those. And Corwin, go and stand where Father can see you.*"

IF THE TABLE SITS SILENT

Do not have Adalinde ask. Prompt with an action: she crouches and starts unbuckling her spurs. She is putting them away, to go and stand in the public stand with her father and watch her brother lose her horse. If the table still doesn't move, they have made a choice. Run it.

CHANGING THE NOMINATION

Adalinde riding needs the nomination changed. **Every route was seeded earlier:**

Route	What it takes
Weisel signs	The Tanner's Rest, five minutes at a run. Find him: Investigation DC 12, or automatic if they asked about him before. Make him sign: Intimidation DC 15, Persuasion DC 17, or 50 marks. Blackmail him with the rented-colors scheme: automatic, and he hates them forever, which costs nothing today. "*I rent cloth. I don't rent promises. If the boy told you I'd stand in a stewards' tent and swear for him, the boy misheard.*"
A new sponsor	A Roodberg or Meerijder breeder willing to sign for a share of the mare's first foal. Automatic with a clan-kin PC who spends the favor; otherwise Persuasion DC 15 in the enclosures.
Roodberg bends the rule	Persuasion DC 17 (DC 12 with a clan name vouching): the rule serves the race better bent than kept. He does it once, and he writes down why.
Otwin signs	Only after the party has said Adalinde should ride, never before. Persuasion DC 13 if the ledger argument was won in Scene 2 or he has watched the swap; DC 17 otherwise. He signs for a dead house in his own hand, which is the closest a Halbritter has ever come to colors.

THE OTHER ROUTES

- **Buy the note down:** stake money at 4-to-1 to place (the purse share, the bet, or both).
- **Scratch her and take the offer:** Corwin says yes if the party tells him to.
- **Run Corwin anyway:** nothing needed.

OTWIN, WATCHING THE SWAP

He doesn't say anything. He looks at his daughter in the silks, and at his son standing in the row with empty hands, and something in his face does arithmetic and comes out different than it went in.

THE RACE — THREE SENTENCES, NO ROLLS

Adalinde rides, Maus Sound:

> *They go off in a wall of noise and she's nowhere for half a mile: buried, boxed, a grey nothing at the back of a clan field. Then at the turn there's a gap that isn't really a gap, and she takes it. She doesn't win; the Roodberg colt wins by a length and a half. But a grey farm mare in a dead house's colors comes second at Duffkyyn, and up in the public stand an old man with the gout is on his feet without knowing he stood up.*

Corwin rides:

> *He rides well. That's the thing nobody expected and nobody will remember: he rides well, for a boy who's never ridden a race, and he finishes sixth in a field of eleven. The mare comes back sound and blowing and pleased with herself. Sixth pays nothing. He knows it before he's out of the saddle, and he doesn't look for his father in the stand.*

Maus Sore, and they run her (roll the 1-in-6 in the open, first):

> *No breakdown: She runs fourth on three good legs and a lie, and every horseman on that rail knows what they just watched. Breakdown: At the last furlong something goes out of her stride, the whole rail makes one sound, and she pulls up. She'll walk. She won't race. Adalinde is over the rail before anyone can stop her.*

DEVELOPMENT

- **Adalinde rides, Sound** → second; the 500-mark place purse clears the note. Maus is now a broodmare, not a remount, and Otwin strikes her from the levy string in his own hand.
- **Corwin rides** → sixth, sound. The note falls due; Erlenhof goes to the Day 6 ring unless the party has arranged otherwise.
- **Past the third bell** → scratched. Vuurzward's offer stands at Derby-evening prices, which are worse.
- **Sore** → she can run or she can be kept whole, not both. Adalinde says so and lets the party decide: "*She can run. I don't know that she should.*" Fourth pays nothing and does not clear the note.
- **Lame** → she cannot run. The entry is scratched, and Vuurzward's offer is the only route left. He knows it.
- **Vuurzward** plays at full intelligence: odds bought down, gone before the last furlong. He has done nothing a court can hang him for. If the party laid Krul and the odds-book before Roodberg (Scene 5), his own horses are barred and he is not here at all.

CLUES AVAILABLE HERE

- The steward's boy → **whoever signs names the rider** (last resort)
- The boots → **Adalinde should ride**

PROOF

- If someone mentions the purse, Corwin works it out aloud: "*Second's five hundred. The note's four.*" → **second place is enough** (last resort)

SENSORY PALETTE

- **Sight:** green silks over riding boots, the crowd four deep, a steward's boy at the post
- **Sound:** the bell for the second race, a crowd coming apart at the turn
- **Smell:** crushed turf, horse sweat, a thousand people's beer
- **Touch:** silk still warm from the person who handed it over
- **Taste:** dust off the course

ALTERNATES & RE-HOOKS

- **Adalinde came instead of Corwin** (they refused the job): the problem at post time is Otwin, who arrives to take the mare home. The same routes work on him; the ledger argument is the strongest.
- **Otwin has been here since Scene 5** (the roll): he stands in the row the whole scene. He speaks only if a PC speaks to him first.
- **The mare was sold to the Rhennee** (Scene 4): a 10-minute beat. Otwin and Adalinde come off the morning packet to an empty stall and a struck line. Adalinde looks at the stall, then at the party: "*You sold her to the water.*" She says nothing else until the sale ring, where she still delivers the letter. Otwin says nothing at all; the note is paid, and that is the worst part. Go to Scene 08 — The Sale Ring.
- **A PC cut a cord in Scene 6:** Roodberg has already struck the line. The only routes left are a very good reason (Persuasion DC 20, with the bravos' cut cords as evidence) or Vuurzward's offer.

TRANSITION

- → Scene 08 — The Sale Ring: the morning after, the ring half empty, and an old man sitting on the rail.

PROOF

SCENE 08 — THE SALE RING

PURPOSE

Land it. Hand them the evidence about Hessel, let them decide whether to tell Otwin, and give them the patron's letter on almost every branch.

ARRIVAL

> *The ring is half empty the morning after. Yearlings go through at a hundred marks a head, a man with a ledger calls prices in a bored singsong, and the whole Flats smells of packing up. Otwin Halbritter is sitting on the rail. He came for the noon signing and did it; the contract is signed, thirty head over three years. But he watched the last two furlongs from the public stand first, and told nobody, and he is telling you now.*

To the table: "*He doesn't look at you. He says, 'I saw. I saw the whole of it.' Who sits down next to him?*"

WHO IS HERE

- **Otwin Halbritter**. *Wants:* quiet, to redo the sums. *Knows:* what he saw. *Reacts:* to his daughter, without turning: "*Don't. Don't say anything, girl. I've the ledger in my head and I'm doing the sums again and I'd like quiet for it.*"
- **Adalinde Halbritter**, with a folded paper.
- **Corwin Halbritter**, wherever his father can see him.

BEATS

THE TRUTH ABOUT HESSEL

Krul's *ten days*, the odds-book account opened ten days ago, Grete's ale line and Tilo's word about the sergeant's wife: together they name **Hessel Amtmann**. Leave it as evidence, not a confession. **Whether to tell Otwin is the last decision in the adventure, and it is the party's.**

If they tell him, give them the moment and don't rush it:

> *He listens all the way through without interrupting, which is worse than shouting. "Hessel." He says the name like he's checking a number he already knew was wrong. "Fifteen years. He carried my son on his shoulders at the Godsday fair." He gets down off the rail, slowly, because of the gout. "Right. Thank you. I'd rather have known."*

THE STEWARDS' CHEST

By Duffkyyn custom, the company that brought a starter to the post draws one prize from the stewards' chest. Benno carries it round the ring. Any branch where the mare reached the Flats under the party's escort qualifies, whether she ran or was scratched; the Rhennee sale does not. Roll on the **Derby prize table** in this adventure (Treasure & Rewards).

THE LETTER

However it ended, even if they took Vuurzward's offer, Adalinde finds them with a folded paper and a face that gives nothing away:

"*The Roodbergs have sold remounts to the University's field station since its charter. The Registrar knows the seal.*" She hands it over. "*It's a letter of field expertise. It won't buy your passage, and you don't need it for the door; they take anyone who signs. It's for after. She'll write it in a different column from everyone else's.*"

(If they saved the farm:) "*Father's paying your passage, and half your bond. He says he's buying your absence from my stable. He isn't. He just can't say the other thing.*"

(And then, because she owes them one true sentence:) "*Whatever else happened out there, thank you for asking me whether I ride. Nobody ever thought to ask.*"

Hand over Handout — The Patron's Letter with the commendations they earned written in.

WHAT HAPPENS NEXT

- **The farm stands** (Adalinde placed, or the note bought down): Maus goes home a broodmare. Her first foal is three years out.
- **The note fell due:** Erlenhof goes through this ring this afternoon. Vuurzward bids. The party can stay and watch, or help Adalinde buy the

PROOF

mare back (she has 60 marks; the mare goes for 150).

- **The Rhennee sale:** the farm stands and the name is gone. Nobody in the Roodberg enclosure will look at Corwin.
- **The northern packet** leaves on Godsday: one night along the shore to Ritterstadt's quay.

DEVELOPMENT

- **Told Otwin** → the last commendation in the patron's letter. Hessel is dismissed by the end of Reaping.
- **Didn't tell him** → Hessel keeps his post, and his Kettenhaus paper is struck out. That is all.
- **Left open:** six hundred marks for a farm mare is far too much. Who on the barges wanted her, and how did they know she'd be on that boat? Sivert's 400 and Hessel's 60 both trace to the Kettenhaus of Traft, which holds Ritter Konrad von Eisfeld's Schuldbrief. The party will hear that name again in Ritterstadt.

CLUES AVAILABLE HERE

- Adalinde, last resort: "*Hessel booked the passage. Nobody else knew the day.*" → **Hessel sold the route**

SENSORY PALETTE

- **Sight:** a half-empty ring, a ledger, an old man on a rail
- **Sound:** the auctioneer's singsong, pavilions coming down
- **Smell:** trodden straw, cold cook-fires
- **Touch:** a folded letter with a Roodberg seal
- **Taste:** the last of the Derby beer, flat

ALTERNATES & RE-HOOKS

- **The party left the Flats after the race.** Adalinde finds them at the lake-gate before the packet sails.
- **Otwin isn't speaking to them** (they took Vuurzward's offer): the Hessel evidence goes to Adalinde instead, and the choice is the same.

TRANSITION

- → **Ritterstadt.** The northern packet, one night along the shore, and The Landing at dawn. *(The campaign continues there.)*

PROOF

APPENDIX A — THE MARE, THE CLOCK AND THE CORD

THE MARE, THE CLOCK AND THE CORD

The adventure runs on one law, one track and two clocks. Put them on an index card where the players can see them. **Maus's Condition** is the real stake of Acts 2 and 3. The **Sabotage Clock** is how she loses it. The **Spook die** is what forty frightened horses do to a fight. The **peace-bond** is the law on the Flats.

MAUS'S CONDITION (THE TRACK)

Maus is not a combatant and should never roll initiative.

State	How	At post time
Sound	The Sabotage Clock never filled	Can place second. Every route in Scene 7 is open.
Sore	The clock filled once	Animal Handling DC 15 or Medicine DC 13 to detect; automatic for Adalinde and for any PC with a stable, farrier or cavalry background. She can run, but **fourth is her ceiling**, and there is a **1 in 6** she breaks down in the last furlong.
Lame	The clock filled twice	She cannot run. The entry is scratched, and Vuurzward's offer is the only route left.

Give the players the choice, not the roll. If she is Sore, Adalinde says so plainly: "*She can run. I don't know that she should.*" Never roll the breakdown in secret; roll it in the open, before the race, if they choose to run her. A breakdown ends her racing life, not her life: she is still a broodmare, and still worth having.

Why laming her doesn't spoil Vuurzward's prize: Krul's trade is a pricked sole, a nail an inch too deep. It heals in a month. Vuurzward wants the mare beaten on Derby Day, not ruined.

THE SABOTAGE CLOCK (SCENE 4, SCENE 6)

The saboteur needs **three uninterrupted rounds** at the mare's stall. Mark them where the players can see: [ ][ ][ ]. - The saboteur spends a whole turn adjacent to the mare to mark one round. - **Interrupting him at any point resets the count to zero.** - **Three marks** drop Maus one Condition step, whatever happens to the saboteur afterward. - **A watch that fails to notice him:** he starts with one mark already placed. **No watch at all:** no roll; he gets his three rounds. - **Several saboteurs** (the Scene 6 bravos): one mark per round in which at least one of them works at the stall uninterrupted. Interrupting any one of them does not reset the count; interrupting all of them at the stall does.

Detection (Scene 4): passive Perception 13 for anyone on watch on deck; Perception DC 15 from below decks (the mare's hooves shifting wrong); a PC who knows horses has advantage and notices one round earlier.

THE SPOOK DIE (SCENE 6)

Forty horses in narrow rows. Track a d6 in the open, starting at 0.

Rises by 1	Rises by 2	Falls by 1
A shout; a body hitting a stall wall; a lantern dropped or swung; a horse taking damage; a stall door left open	Any fire effect	A PC spends an action calming horses (**Animal Handling DC 12**)

- **At 3:** the horses in the row scream. Disadvantage on Perception checks in the row, and Maus needs **Animal Handling DC 13** or she is unusable in Scene 7's opening minutes.
- **At 5: stampede.** Every creature in the row makes a **DC 13 Dexterity saving throw**, taking 7 (2d6) bludgeoning damage on a failure or half as much on a success. The row is difficult terrain for 3 rounds. A creature at 0 hit points takes an automatic 2d6 unless dragged clear, and the bravos will help drag. Nobody wants a dead man on the Flats.

THE PEACE-BOND (THE LAW; SCENE 5 ONWARD)

During Richfest week the Duffkyyn Flats are under a *Landfrieden* proclaimed in the Voormann's name. At the Flats gate the stewards' men knot a **red**

cord through every hilt and scabbard and seal it with wax: "*Landfrieden. Derby peace. Cut it and you hang.*"

Allowed	Breaks the peace
Fists, grapples, shoves; improvised weapons (see Scene 6's list)	Cutting your own cord (an action, and a crime)
Unarmed strikes, monk features, natural weapons	Drawing a corded weapon in anger (a hanging offense, with forty witnesses)
Spells	—

If a player cuts and draws anyway, let them. It works. The stewards' men arrive in 1d4 rounds, and the cost lands in Scene 7: Roodberg strikes the Ostvelt line on the spot unless the party can produce a very good reason.

One custom, two places. Schwartzenbruin's company taverns took the red cord from the Derby peace. At The Red Cord, cutting your cord makes every company in the room your enemy; on the Flats, it makes the Voormann's hangman your enemy. See SP-PBS-03-The-Red-Cord.

STEWARD ROODBERG'S ATTITUDE (SCENE 5, SCENE 7)

Hostile / **Indifferent** / Friendly. He starts **Indifferent**. - **One step worse:** blood spilled on the road (a PC recognized by name at the gate), or money offered to him. - **One step better:** correct papers; a Roodberg or Meerijder name vouching; Krul produced as a witness with the odds-book account. - **Friendly** halves the DC to bend the sponsor rule in Scene 7.

TABLE CARD

- Maus: **Sound** / Sore / Lame
- Sabotage Clock: [ ][ ][ ]
- Spook die: 0 1 2 3 4 5
- Roodberg: Hostile / **Indifferent** / Friendly
- The third bell after noon, Richfest 4

PROOF

APPENDIX B — BESTIARY

BESTIARY — NOBODY'S COLORS

All statblocks use **2014 5e** rules. MM page numbers refer to the 2014 *Monster Manual*. Every creature here is a stock block with a short list of changes, so the session runs from this file alone.

STANDING RULES

- **Nobody here is evil.** Every hostile is a working person doing a paid job in a canton where everyone has cousins. All of them **surrender at or below a quarter of their hit points**, talk when captured, and do not pursue a fleeing party.
- **Killing has a name.** Killing a clansman without a declared *Fehde* is murder, and his clan carries it for a generation. A PC who kills a Meerijder or Vuurzward retainer is recognized at the Flats gate, and Steward Roodberg starts one step worse. Say this aloud **before** initiative.
- **Knocking out is free.** Any melee attack may knock a creature out instead of killing it. Remind the table once, at the bridge.
- **Under the peace-bond** (Scene 6), PCs and bravos alike fight with improvised weapons; see Scene 06 — The Stable Rows and The Mare, the Clock and the Cord.

BOEDIC OF THE MEERIJDER — BANDIT CAPTAIN (CR 2, 450 XP), MM P. 344

Medium humanoid (human), lawful neutral — Boedic of the Meerijder, Scene 2 **AC** 15 (studded leather) · **HP** 65 (10d8 + 20) · **Speed** 30 ft.

STR	DEX	CON	INT	WIS	CHA
15 (+2)	16 (+3)	14 (+2)	14 (+2)	11 (+0)	14 (+2)

Saving Throws Str +4, Dex +5, Wis +2 · **Skills** Athletics +4, Deception +4 · **Senses** passive Perception 10 · **Languages** Common · **Challenge** 2 (450 XP)

Actions ***Multiattack.*** The captain makes three melee attacks: two with its scimitar and one with its dagger. Or the captain makes two ranged attacks with its daggers. ***Scimitar.*** *Melee Weapon Attack:* +5 to hit, reach 5 ft., one target. *Hit:* 6 (1d6 + 3) slashing damage. ***Dagger.*** *Melee or Ranged Weapon Attack:* +5 to hit, reach 5 ft. or range 20/60 ft., one target. *Hit:* 5 (1d4 + 3) piercing damage.

Reactions ***Parry.*** The captain adds 2 to its AC against one melee attack that would hit it. To do so, the captain must see the attacker and be wielding a melee weapon.

Changes from the bandit captain block:

- **Drover's heavy staff** replaces the scimitar: +4 to hit, reach 5 ft., 7 (1d8 + 2) bludgeoning. On a hit he may forgo 4 damage to force a **DC 13 Strength save** or the target drops one held item.
- **Multiattack:** two staff attacks, or one staff attack and one shove. The **belt knife** (the dagger) comes out only if a PC has drawn steel first.
- ***Drover's Footing.*** He ignores difficult terrain created by livestock.
- ***Call Them Off.*** When a drover within 30 ft. drops to 0 HP, Boedic may end the fight by standing his men down. He takes it **the second time** it is available.
- **Script:** round 1 he talks, not attacks. His line holds the bridge and does not advance. His crew targets the wagon team, not the party.

PROOF

MEERIJDER DROVER — THUG (CR 1/2, 100 XP), MM P. 350

Medium humanoid (human), lawful neutral — Scene 2 **AC** 11 (leather armor) · **HP** 32 (5d8 + 10) · **Speed** 30 ft.

STR	DEX	CON	INT	WIS	CHA
15 (+2)	11 (+0)	14 (+2)	10 (+0)	10 (+0)	11 (+0)

Skills Intimidation +2 · **Senses** passive Perception 10 · **Languages** Common · **Challenge** 1/2 (100 XP)

Pack Tactics. The thug has advantage on an attack roll against a creature if at least one of the thug's allies is within 5 ft. of the creature and the ally isn't incapacitated.

Actions ***Multiattack.*** The thug makes two melee attacks. ***Mace.*** *Melee Weapon Attack:* +4 to hit, reach 5 ft., one creature. *Hit:* 5 (1d6 + 2) bludgeoning damage. ***Heavy Crossbow.*** *Ranged Weapon Attack:* +2 to hit, range 100/400 ft., one target. *Hit:* 5 (1d10) piercing damage.

Changes from the thug block:

- **Cattle goad** replaces the mace: +4 to hit, **reach 10 ft.**, 5 (1d6 + 2) piercing.
- **Thrown rope** replaces the crossbow: +4 to hit, range 20/40 ft.; the target is grappled (escape DC 12) and the drover has no free hand while holding it.
- Adds **Animal Handling +2**.

DROVER'S MASTIFF — MASTIFF (CR 1/8, 25 XP), MM P. 332

Medium beast, unaligned — Scene 2, APL 3–4 **AC** 12 · **HP** 9 (2d8) · **Speed** 40 ft.

STR	DEX	CON	INT	WIS	CHA
13 (+1)	14 (+2)	12 (+1)	3 (−4)	12 (+1)	7 (−2)

Skills Perception +3 · **Senses** passive Perception 13 · **Languages** — · **Challenge** 1/8 (25 XP)

Keen Hearing and Smell. The mastiff has advantage on Wisdom (Perception) checks that rely on hearing or smell.

Actions ***Bite.*** *Melee Weapon Attack:* +3 to hit, reach 5 ft., one target. *Hit:* 4 (1d6 + 1) piercing damage. If the target is a creature, it must succeed on a DC 11 Strength saving throw or be knocked prone.

Changes from the mastiff block:

- **Hold** replaces Bite: +3 to hit; the target is **grappled (escape DC 11)** and takes **no damage**. These dogs work cattle and are trained to take cloth, not throat; they won't bite a person who stops moving.
- **HP 9 (2d8)** instead of 5: big cattle dogs.

ANSE KRUL, FARRIER — SPY (CR 1, 200 XP), MM P. 349

Medium humanoid (human), neutral — Anse Krul, Scene 4; Scene 6 at APL 3–4 if he escaped **AC** 12 · **HP** 27 (6d8) · **Speed** 30 ft.

STR	DEX	CON	INT	WIS	CHA
10 (+0)	15 (+2)	10 (+0)	12 (+1)	14 (+2)	16 (+3)

Skills Deception +5, Insight +4, Investigation +5, Perception +6, Persuasion +5, Sleight of Hand +4, Stealth +4 · **Senses** passive Perception 16 · **Languages** Common · **Challenge** 1 (200 XP)

Cunning Action. On each of its turns, the spy can use a bonus action to take the Dash, Disengage, or Hide action. ***Sneak Attack (1/Turn).*** The spy deals an extra 7 (2d6) damage when it hits a target with a weapon attack and has advantage on the attack roll, or when the target is within 5 ft. of an ally of the spy that isn't incapacitated and the spy doesn't have disadvantage on the attack roll.

Actions ***Multiattack.*** The spy makes two melee attacks. ***Shortsword.*** *Melee Weapon Attack:* +4 to hit, reach 5 ft., one target. *Hit:* 5 (1d6 + 2) piercing damage. ***Hand Crossbow.*** *Ranged Weapon Attack:* +4 to hit, range 30/120 ft., one target. *Hit:* 5 (1d6 + 2) piercing damage.

Changes from the spy block:

- **Hoof knife** replaces the shortsword: +4 to hit, 4 (1d4 + 2) piercing, finesse. No hand crossbow.
- **No Sneak Attack.** ***A Tradesman, Not a Killer:*** he never attacks a creature that isn't between him and the horse or the rail, and on his **second turn** of any fight he Dashes or Disengages and leaves. He can swim.
- ***The Work.*** A whole turn adjacent to a restrained or willing horse, uninterrupted, marks the **Sabotage Clock** once.
- Adds **Animal Handling +6** and proficiency with smith's tools.

DECKHAND — THUG (CR 1/2, 100 XP), MM P. 350

Medium humanoid (human), neutral — Scene 4, APL 2–4 Use the **thug** block above with **HP 20**. One carries a **hand crossbow** at APL 3–4 (+2 to hit, range 30/120 ft., 3 (1d6) piercing). Bribed, not loyal: they surrender the moment Krul goes down or bolts.

VUURZWARD BRAVO — THUG (CR 1/2, 100 XP), MM P. 350

Medium humanoid (any race), neutral — Scene 6 Use the **thug** block above, with these **changes**:

- **Cudgel** replaces the mace (same numbers; wood, so it is legal on the Flats).
- **Sap:** +4 to hit, 5 (1d6 + 2) bludgeoning, and the target makes a **DC 12 Constitution save** or has disadvantage on its next attack roll. They aim to disable and withdraw, never to kill.
- ***Cord Already Cut.*** They enter the rows with their peace-bonds cut. It is a hanging offense and they know it, which is why they won't stay for a long fight. **Morale breaks when half are down.**
- ***Drag Him Clear*** (reaction). When a creature within 5 ft., **including a PC**, drops to 0 HP during a stampede, the bravo drags it out of the row.
- Vuurzward green under plain cloaks.

CORWIN HALBRITTER — NOBLE (CR 1/8, 25 XP), MM P. 348

Medium humanoid (human), neutral good — Corwin Halbritter, Scene 6 (if he stands the watch) **AC** 15 (breastplate) · **HP** 9 (2d8) · **Speed** 30 ft.

STR	DEX	CON	INT	WIS	CHA
11 (+0)	12 (+1)	11 (+0)	12 (+1)	14 (+2)	16 (+3)

Skills Deception +5, Insight +4, Persuasion +5 · **Senses** passive Perception 12 · **Languages** Common · **Challenge** 1/8 (25 XP)

Actions ***Rapier.*** *Melee Weapon Attack:* +3 to hit, reach 5 ft., one target. *Hit:* 5 (1d8 + 1) piercing damage.

Reactions ***Parry.*** The noble adds 2 to its AC against one melee attack that would hit it. To do so, the noble must see the attacker and be wielding a melee weapon.

Changes from the noble block:

- **AC 12** (a riding coat, no breastplate) and **HP 11** (2d8 + 2).
- On the Flats his rapier is corded: he fights with a lantern-pole (+2 to hit, 1d6 bludgeoning) and loses Parry.
- Adds **Animal Handling +2**. He will do something brave: his first action is always to shout for help, then to put himself between the bravos and the stall.

MAUS (OSTVELT GREY) — RIDING HORSE (CR 1/4, 50 XP), MM P. 336

Large beast, unaligned — Maus **AC** 10 · **HP** 13 (2d10 + 2) · **Speed** 60 ft.

STR	DEX	CON	INT	WIS	CHA
16 (+3)	10 (+0)	12 (+1)	2 (−4)	11 (+0)	7 (−2)

Senses passive Perception 10 · **Languages** — · **Challenge** 1/4 (50 XP)

Actions ***Hooves.*** *Melee Weapon Attack:* +5 to hit, reach 5 ft., one target. *Hit:* 8 (2d4 + 3) bludgeoning damage.

Changes from the riding horse block:

- ***She Should Never Roll Initiative.*** She is the stake, not a combatant. Stat her only if a player does something that requires it. She kicks only when cornered, frightened, and out of options.
- ***Quiet in the Dark.*** Trained to stand still and silent in an enclosed space (a wagon, a stall, a ship's box) for hours. This is why the smuggling works at all.
- Her Condition (Sound / Sore / Lame) is tracked in The Mare, the Clock and the Cord.

NOT FOUGHT

Who	Why there is no block
Sivert Vuurzward	He never touches a weapon. If a PC attacks him, he does not resist, and the attack is a hanging on the Flats.
Steward Alric Roodberg, Jorick Weisel, Captain Marda Vosk	Social only. Use **commoner** (MM p. 345) or **noble** if a fight somehow starts.
Otwin Halbritter, Adalinde Halbritter	Social only. Adalinde uses **scout** (MM p. 349) if she must ride or run.

ENCOUNTER XP CHECK (4 PCS, 2014 DMG)

Encounter	APL 1	APL 2	APL 3	APL 4
Bridge (avoidable)	750 × 2 = 1,500 — Deadly	950 × 2 = 1,900 — Deadly	1,000 × 2.5 = 2,500 — Deadly	2,500 — Deadly
Deck	200 × 1 = 200 — Medium	300 × 1.5 = 450 — Medium	400 × 2 = 800 — Medium	800 — Easy
Stable rows	200 × 1.5 = 300 — Hard	300 × 2 = 600 — Hard	600 × 2 = 1,200 — Hard	1,200 — Medium

Thresholds for 4 PCs (Easy / Medium / Hard / Deadly): APL 1 — 100 / 200 / 300 / 400; APL 2 — 200 / 400 / 600 / 800; APL 3 — 300 / 600 / 900 / 1,600; APL 4 — 500 / 1,000 / 1,500 / 2,000.

PROOF

APPENDIX C — HANDOUTS

HANDOUT — THE NOTICE

(Good paper. A careful hand. A wax seal with no device on it.)

WANTED Four to six persons of good character and steady nerve for escort duty on behalf of a gentleman of this town, Aerden to Osterschlauss by road, thence by lake passage to **SCHWARTZENBRUIN**, to attend the **DUFFKYYN DERBY**.

Departing first bell, the morning after next. Passage paid. Board paid. **Thirty marks** per person on arrival, bearing arms.

Enquire at **ERLENHOF** — the grey house at the top of the hill — and ask for **Sergeant Amtmann**.

ART · Notice paper texture (Art Brief §5)

HANDOUT — THE PATRON'S LETTER

(Heavy paper, folded in three. A blue-over-white seal: the Roodberg band.)

To the Registrar of the Greyhawk University Field Station at Ritterstadt, greeting.

The bearers of this letter came to the Duffkyyn this Richfest in the service of Erlenhof, a house with which my family has dealt in horses for three generations. I write what was told me by the Jungfer Adalinde Halbritter, who has never in my hearing said a thing that was not so.

She asks me to set down that they:

- _____
- _____
- _____

I commend them to you as persons of field judgment, and I ask that this letter be entered where such letters are entered.

Written in the Roodberg enclosure on the Duffkyyn Flats, Richfest, 576 CY.

— Margarethe Roodberg, of the Roodberg studs at Clatspurgen

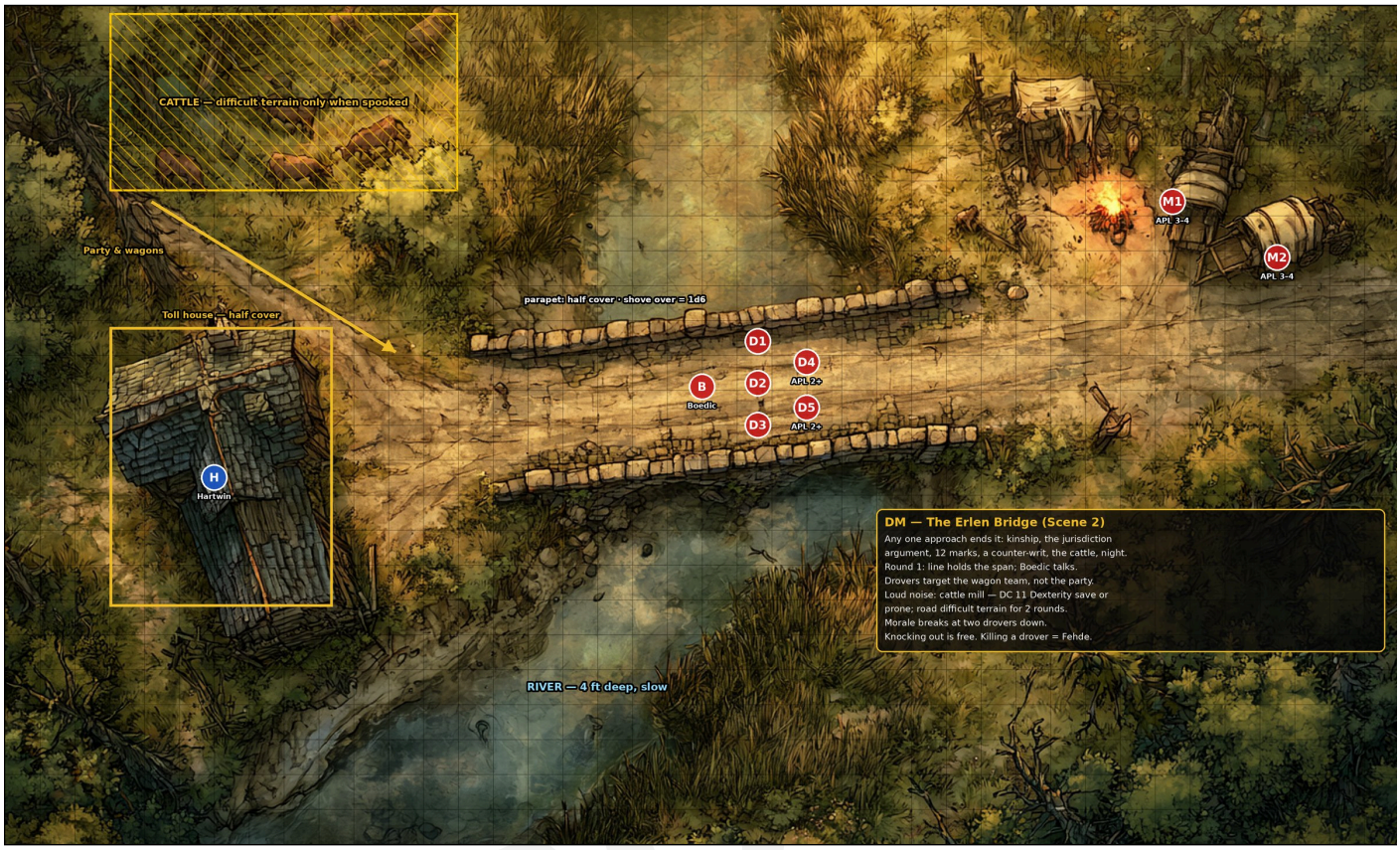
PROOF

APPENDIX D — MAPS

Each map appears twice: the DM copy, with start positions, zones and the scene's rules, then the player copy with the grid only.

PROOF

THE ERLEN BRIDGE (SCENE 2) — DM MAP



1 square = 5 feet · 40 × 24 squares · DM copy: start positions, zones and the scene rules. Do not show players. Full-resolution files (100 px per square) are in 99-Assets/SP-PBS-00.

PROOF

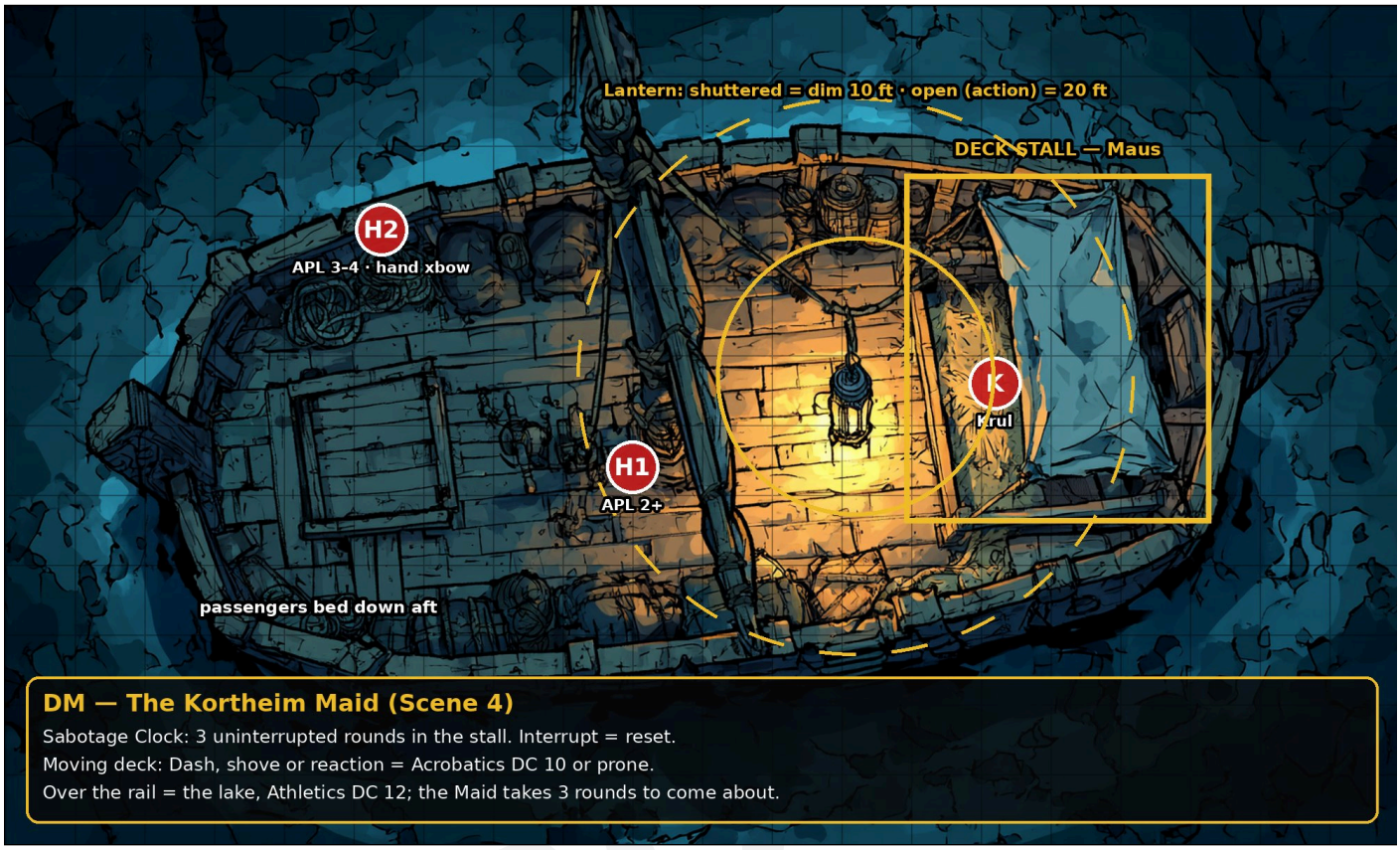
THE ERLEN BRIDGE (SCENE 2) — PLAYER MAP



1 square = 5 feet · 40 × 24 squares · Player copy: grid only. Full-resolution files (100 px per square) are in 99-Assets/SP-PBS-00.

PROOF

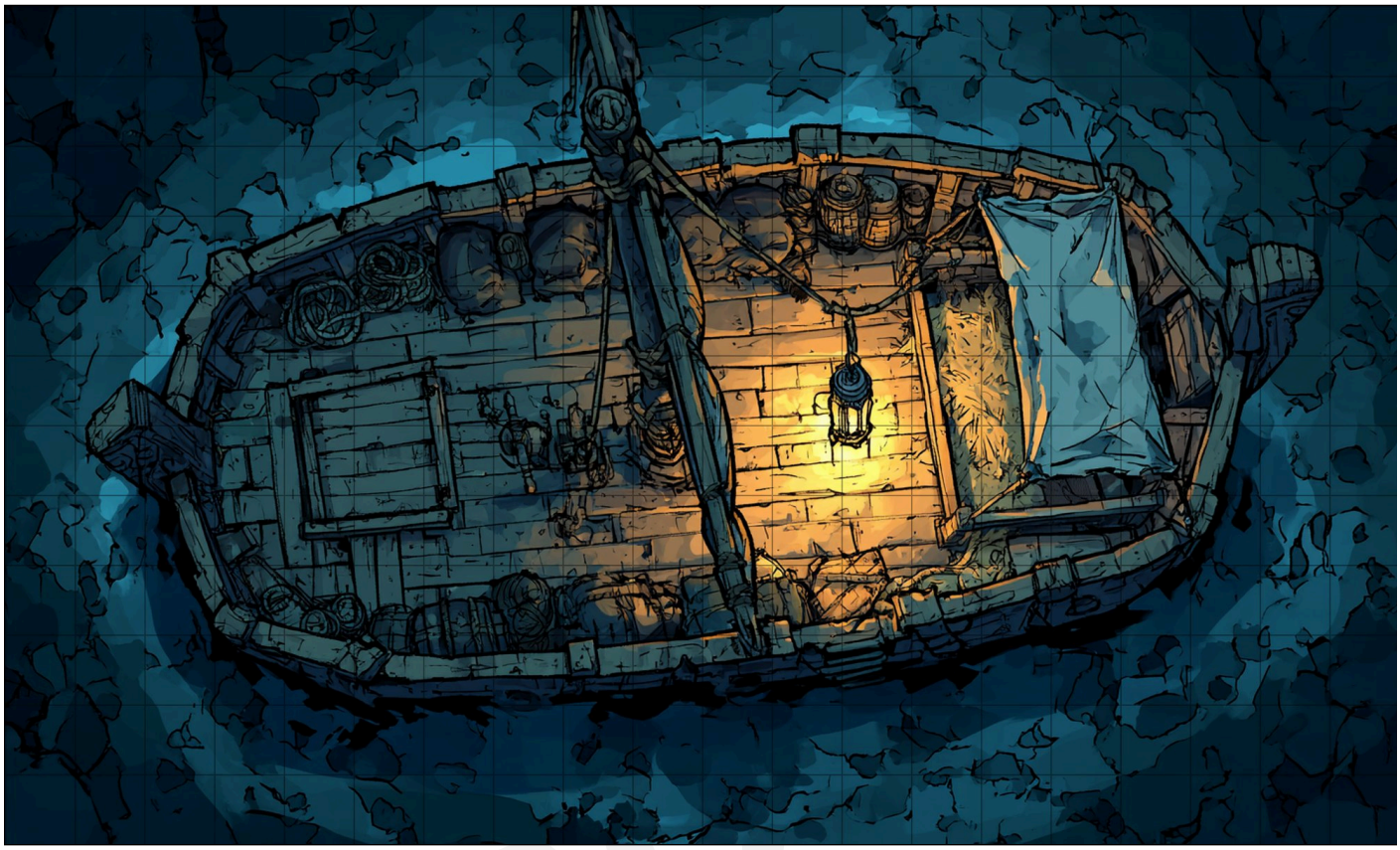
THE KORTHEIM MAID (SCENE 4) — DM MAP



1 square = 5 feet · 20 × 12 squares · DM copy: start positions, zones and the scene rules. Do not show players. Full-resolution files (100 px per square) are in 99-Assets/SP-PBS-00.

PROOF

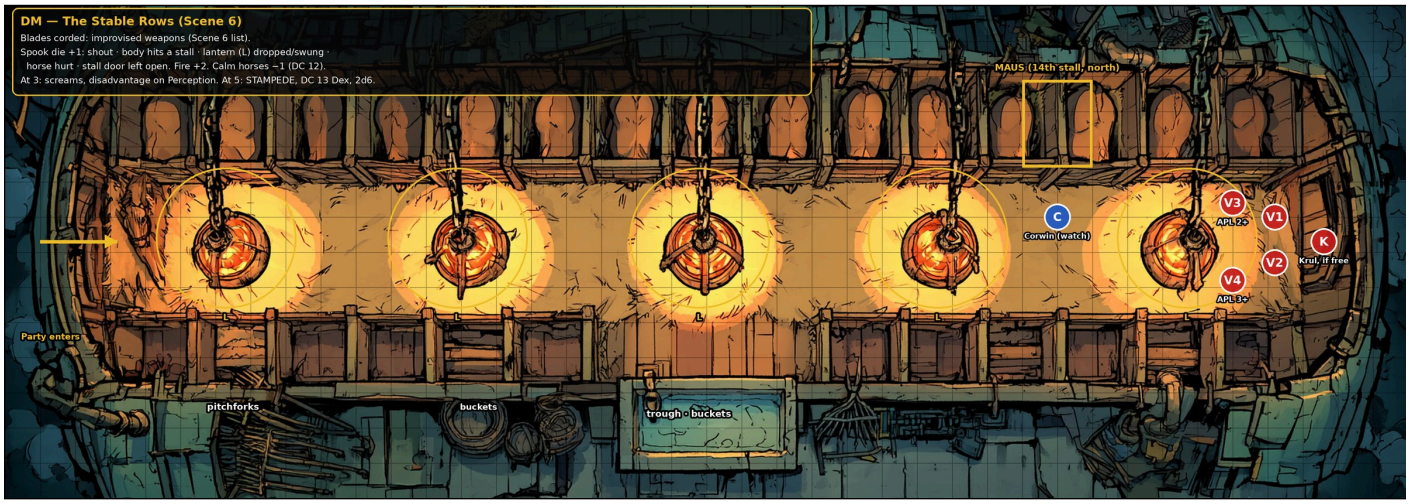
THE KORTHEIM MAID (SCENE 4) — PLAYER MAP



1 square = 5 feet · 20 × 12 squares · Player copy: grid only. Full-resolution files (100 px per square) are in 99-Assets/SP-PBS-00.

PROOF

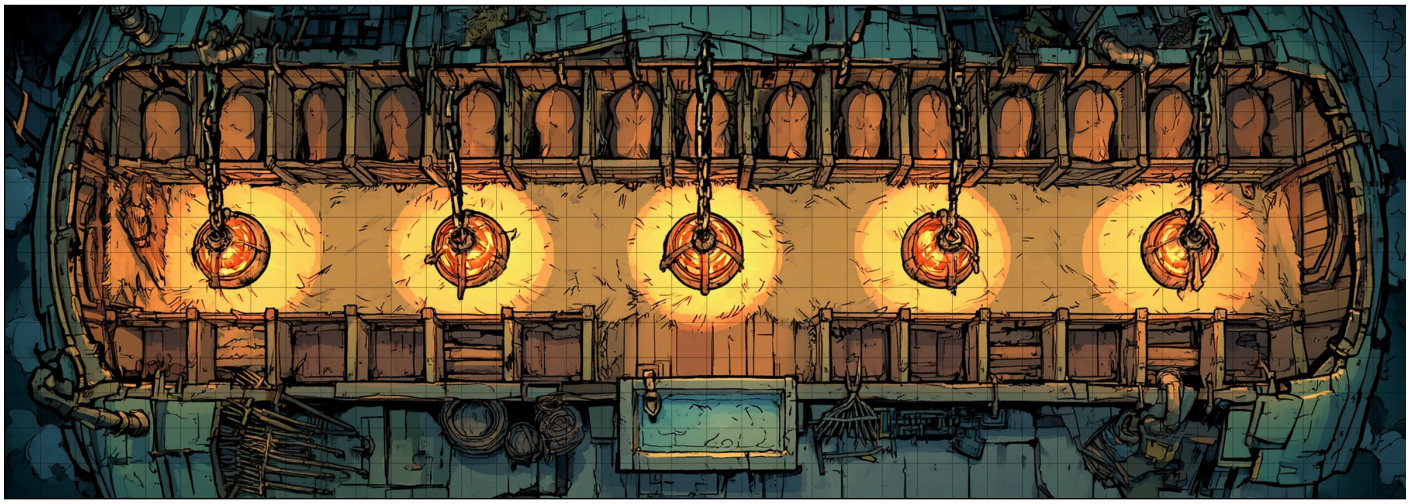
THE STABLE ROWS (SCENE 6) — DM MAP



1 square = 5 feet · 40 × 14 squares · DM copy: start positions, zones and the scene rules. Do not show players. Full-resolution files (100 px per square) are in 99-Assets/SP-PBS-00.

PROOF

THE STABLE ROWS (SCENE 6) — PLAYER MAP



1 square = 5 feet · 40 × 14 squares · Player copy: grid only. Full-resolution files (100 px per square) are in 99-Assets/SP-PBS-00.

PROOF